

Fate's Edge: Game Master's Guide

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Fate's Edge: Game Master's Guide

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Contents

1	Introduction: The Weight of Choice	1
1.1	A World Alive with Consequences	1
1.2	Core Philosophy: Narrative First	1
1.3	Risk as the Engine of Drama	2
1.4	Characters Who Change the World	2
1.5	Your Toolkit	2
1.6	How to Use This Book	2
1.7	Begin the Journey	4
2	Running the Game: Core Procedures	5
2.1	How to Think in Fate's Edge	5
2.1.1	The Core Loop (In Practice)	5
2.1.2	Your Defaults	5
2.1.3	What You Are <i>Not</i> Doing	6
2.1.4	What You <i>Are</i> Doing	6
2.1.5	A Useful Reframe	6
2.2	Optional Initiative Procedures	7
2.2.1	When to Use Structured Initiative	7
2.2.2	Option A: Popcorn Initiative	7
2.2.3	Option B: Side-Based Initiative	7
2.2.4	Option C: Speed-Based Slots	7
2.2.5	Mixing Narrative and Structured Initiative	8
2.2.6	Recommendation for New GMs	8
2.3	Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules	9
2.3.1	Scope (What Counts as a Module)	9
2.3.2	Core Principle	9
2.3.3	Player Duties	9
2.3.4	GM Duties	10
2.3.5	Standard Thresholds & Effects	10
2.3.6	Table Procedure (90-Second Loop)	10
2.3.7	Disputes & Order of Operations	10
2.3.8	Accessibility & Tools	11
2.3.9	Worked Micro-Examples	11
	First Game Scenario: The Sunstone Tower	11
2.4	Learning Through Examples	12
2.5	The Core Resolution Cycle	13

2.6	Story Beats: The Engine of Drama	15
2.6.1	Failing Forward with SB	15
2.7	Combat Made Simple	15
2.7.1	Three-Beat Combat Structure	16
2.8	Clocks & Fronts	16
2.8.1	Basic Clock Usage	16
2.8.2	Mini-Fronts for Short Arcs	16
2.9	Ready for More? Add These Systems	17
2.9.1	Boons	17
2.9.2	Advanced Magic	17
2.9.3	Followers, Assets, and Domains	17
2.10	Abstracting Time and Currency	17
2.10.1	Narrative Time (Not Minutes)	17
2.10.2	Abstract Currency (XP as Coin)	17
2.11	Session Flow: A GM Cognitive Checklist	18
2.11.1	Opening 10 Minutes	18
2.11.2	During Play	18
2.11.3	Closing 10 Minutes	18
3	Managing Resources	23
3.1	Supply Clock: The Pulse of Survival	23
3.1.1	Supply Clock States	23
3.1.2	When to Advance the Supply Clock	23
3.1.3	Clearing Supply Segments	23
3.2	Fatigue: The Weight of the World	24
3.2.1	Fatigue Effects	24
3.2.2	Clearing Fatigue	24
3.2.3	Fatigue → Harm Conversion	24
3.3	Boons: The Currency of Resilience	25
3.3.1	Earning Boons (GM Reminders)	25
3.3.2	Boon Economy (Quick Reference)	25
3.3.3	Spending Boons (Player Options)	25
3.3.4	Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)	25
3.4	Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self	25
3.4.1	Followers: On-Screen Allies	25
3.4.2	Assets: Off-Screen Influence	26
3.5	Terrestrial Patrons: Favours and Debts	27
3.5.1	How Terrestrial Patrons Work	27
3.5.2	Examples of Terrestrial Patron Debts	27
3.5.3	Running Terrestrial Patrons	28
3.5.4	Optional: Terrestrial Patron Reputation	28
3.6	XP Awards: Growth Through Choice	28
3.6.1	Milestones	28
3.7	Campaign Resources: Mandate and Crisis	28
3.7.1	Mandate Clock (0–6)	28
3.7.2	Crisis Clock (0–6)	29
3.8	Combat Resource Management	29
3.8.1	Supply in Combat	29

3.8.2	Fatigue in Combat	29
3.8.3	Follower Combat Integration	29
3.8.4	Tactical Clocks	29
3.8.5	Over-Stack Trigger	30
3.9	Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger	30
4	Magic and Backlash	31
4.1	The Role of Magic in Your Game	31
4.2	Adjudicating Magic at the Table	31
4.3	Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)	33
4.4	Managing Obligation and Corruption	34
4.5	Summoning (GM-Facing)	34
4.6	Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)	35
4.7	Ritual Magic (GM Advice)	35
4.8	Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar	36
4.9	Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)	36
5	Campaigns, Clocks, and Consequences	39
5.0.1	How to Scale Position Without Bloat	49
5.0.2	What Position Means for GM Decisions	49
5.0.3	Position and Narrative Momentum	49
5.0.4	What Not To Do	49
5.0.5	GM Mindset	50
5.0.6	Quick Start Campaigns	55
5.0.6.1	The Sunstone Gambit	55
5.0.6.2	Modular Session Structure	55
5.0.7	Tier-Appropriate Design	55
5.0.7.1	Tier I-II Campaigns (0-90 XP)	55
5.0.7.2	Tier III Campaigns (91-150 XP)	56
5.0.7.3	Tiers IV-V Campaigns (151+ XP)	56
5.1	Scaling Threats	56
5.1.1	Threat Evolution Framework	56
5.1.2	Threat Customization by Tier	56
5.2	Branching Narrative Design	57
5.2.1	Consequence-Driven Branching	57
5.2.2	Branching Structure Types	57
5.3	Character Arc Planning	57
5.3.1	Defining Character Growth	57
5.3.1.1	Internal Arcs	57
5.3.1.2	External Arcs	58
5.3.2	Integrating Arcs with Campaign	58
5.3.2.1	Campaign Alignment	58
5.3.2.2	Ongoing Integration	58
5.3.3	Measuring Progress	58
5.3.3.1	Narrative Milestones	58
5.3.3.2	Mechanical Milestones	59
6	Advanced GM Techniques	61

6.1	Advanced Story Beat Management	61
6.2	Mastering the Deck of Consequences	62
6.3	Advanced Travel and Genre Blending	62
6.4	Faction Grand Strategy	63
6.5	Designing High-Tier Custom Content	63
6.6	Running Mythic Scenarios (Tiers IV–V)	64
6.7	Advanced Complex Scenarios	64
6.8	When to Say Yes, No, and Yes, But – Advanced Rulings	65
7	Enhanced GM Play	67
7.1	The GM as Player: A Philosophy	67
7.2	Playing with Story Beats	68
7.3	A Light Game for You: Threat Pool (Optional)	68
7.4	Pacing and Tension Tactics (For GM Enjoyment)	68
7.5	Handling Player Indecision (Without Frustration)	69
7.6	Adjusting Difficulty on the Fly (For Smoother Play)	69
7.7	Spotlight Management (Share the Love)	70
7.8	Using Failure to Advance the Plot (Make It Fun for You)	70
7.9	Foreshadowing and Secrets (Reward Your Own Curiosity)	70
7.10	Running Cliffhangers (Your Dramatic Exit)	70
7.11	Recovering from Bad Rulings (Gracefully)	71
7.12	Lightweight Faction Loyalty (Optional – For Your Sandbox)	71
7.13	Complication Trading (Player Choice, Your Delight)	71
7.14	Cross-Cultural Synergy (Creativity Tip)	71
7.15	Final Thought: You Are Playing Too	72
8	Tier IV and V: Running Epic Adventures	73
8.1	What Changes at Tier IV–V	73
8.2	Natural Scaling: The Boon Economy Does the Work	73
8.3	Do Not Inflate Difficulty Values	74
8.4	Failure Must Matter	75
8.5	Using Bonds as the Primary Boon Engine	75
8.6	Designing High-Tier Scenes	75
8.7	Pacing and Scope	75
8.8	Caveats and Warnings	76
8.9	Optional Epic Tools (Brief)	76
8.10	Sample High-Tier Scenario: The Dying Sun	77
8.11	Final Thought	77
9	The Known World: A Lore Compendium	79
9.1	A Note on Subgenres and Travel	79
9.2	Acasia — “The Broken Province”	79
9.3	Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”	80
9.4	Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”	80
9.5	Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”	81
9.6	Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”	81
9.7	Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”	82
9.8	Linn — “Skeries & Storm-Oaths”	82

9.9	Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”	83
9.10	Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Dyewater”	83
9.11	Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”	84
9.12	Thepyrgos — “City of a Thousand Stairs”	84
9.13	Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”	85
9.14	Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”	85
9.15	Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”	86
9.16	Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”	86
9.17	Ykrul (Orcs) — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”	87
9.18	Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”	87
9.19	Other Regions (Brief)	88
9.20	Using This Compendium at the Table	88
10	Example Play and GM Survival Guide	89
10.1	The GM as Player: A Quick Refresher	89
10.2	Example Session: The Heist at Lord Silas’s Manor	89
10.3	High-Tier Play in Brief (Tier IV–V)	92
10.4	GM Survival Guide	92

Chapter 1

Introduction: The Weight of Choice

Welcome, Game Master. You hold a unique role in **Fate's Edge**. You are not a solitary storyteller, nor a neutral referee. You are the **weaver of consequences**, the architect of a living world, and the guide on a path where every choice echoes. Your task is to breathe life into a realm of ancient magic, fallen empires, and vibrant cultures—and then let that world respond to the players' ambitions.

Power demands a price. The past never truly sleeps. One decision can reshape a nation or end an age. From the marble forums of Ecktoria to the mist-drenched fens of the Mistlands, the world is alive with stories. Your job is to provide the stage, set the stakes, and embrace the ripple effects of player agency.

1.1 A World Alive with Consequences

In **Fate's Edge**, the fiction is the final authority. The rules are not chains on your imagination, but tools to give weight to your stories. They help you adjudicate risk, track progress, and ensure that both success and failure drive the narrative forward.

Think of yourself as a conductor. The players provide the melody with their characters' actions. You provide the harmony and rhythm with the world's response. The rules are your sheet music—a guide to create a cohesive, dramatic piece, but one that allows improvisation.

Your judgment is the cornerstone of the game. If a rule doesn't serve the moment, change it. If a player's creative idea deserves to succeed, make it work. Your goal is a collaborative story that everyone helps create.

1.2 Core Philosophy: Narrative First

At the heart of **Fate's Edge** is a simple idea: **mechanics serve the story**. A dice roll is never just pass/fail. It changes the fictional landscape.

- **Clean Success** – The plan works as intended.
- **Success with Cost** – You get what you want, but the world pushes back.
- **Partial** – You make progress, but the situation remains unresolved.
- **Miss** – You fail, and the situation escalates.

This ensures every roll matters. The story never stalls; it evolves.

1.3 Risk as the Engine of Drama

Fate's Edge is built on **meaningful risk**. Safety is boring. When characters have something to lose—reputation, allies, ideals, life—their actions become heroic or tragically memorable.

Your primary tool for managing risk is the **Story Beat (SB)** economy. When the dice show a **1**, the world reacts. The GM gains SB to introduce complications, escalate threats, or reveal hidden dangers. **Important:** SB are generated on *any* roll that produces a 1, whether the overall roll succeeds or fails. They are not punishment; they are fuel for an unpredictable, responsive narrative.

Example: A successful sword swing defeats an opponent. A Story Beat spent could mean the blade is notched, or that the defeat draws a more powerful foe. The drama continues.

1.4 Characters Who Change the World

Character growth in **Fate's Edge** is not about accumulating abstract power. It is **meaningful growth** rooted in the story. Players earn **Experience Points (XP)** by engaging with challenges and complexities. They spend XP to improve capabilities, acquire assets (a ship, a spy network), or unlock cultural talents.

Thus, advancement ties directly to narrative. A character becomes a legendary commander by leading armies, not by grinding monsters. A wizard masters forbidden lore by surviving backlash. As GM, you curate this growth, presenting challenges that make evolution feel earned and impactful.

1.5 Your Toolkit

To help guide the story, **Fate's Edge** provides interconnected tools:

- **Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s. 6+ = Success. 1 = Story Beat (SB) for you. Compare successes to Difficulty Value (DV) set by stakes.
- **Position & Effect:** Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) defines stakes of failure. Effect (Limited/Standard/Great) describes what a clean success achieves.
- **Clocks:** Visual trackers for ongoing challenges (e.g., 4-segment lock, 8-segment faction rise).
- **Deck of Consequences (optional):** A standard deck to generate thematic complications when SB are spent. Suits suggest nature of trouble.

These tools are designed to be learned quickly and used intuitively, getting out of the way so you and your players focus on the story.

1.6 How to Use This Book

This guide is for running the game.

- Early chapters cover core principles and basic procedures.
- Later chapters dive into advanced systems (conflict, travel, long-term play).
- Final sections provide guidance for high-tier campaigns, world-building, and the Amaranthine Sea setting.
- Appendices offer practical advice and a collection of tools and tables.

You don't need to memorize everything. Use this book as a reference. The most important chapters to internalize are those on core philosophy (this chapter) and basic action resolution (see SRD ??).

Safety Tools: Lines, Veils & X-Card

Fate's Edge explores mature themes – conflict, loss, horror, betrayal, and difficult choices. The table must always feel safe. Use these three simple tools.

X-Card (by John Stavropoulos). Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” or say “X” when uncomfortable. The described content is **removed from the fiction** – no questions, no explanations. The scene is retconned or redirected.

Lines. A hard boundary: content that will not appear at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Players name their Lines before the campaign; the group honors them.

Veils. A soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. The event is acknowledged but not described. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.” Veils let you acknowledge mature themes without forcing players to roleplay through them.

How to Use.

- Establish Lines and Veils in Session Zero. Write them down where everyone can see.
- Keep an X-Card visible (printed card, drawn X, or digital symbol).
- Remind players they can use the X-Card at any time, even mid-sentence.
- When the X-Card is used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate.
- The GM is also a player; they may use the X-Card for their own comfort.
- Respect the tools. If someone calls an X-Card, trust they had a good reason.

These tools are not about censorship – they are about **consent**. They allow the table to tell darker, more intense stories because everyone knows they can tap out. A safe game is a game that can go to the edge.

Flavor is Free

Players and GMs: In Fate's Edge, flavor is free!

Add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or rolls. Want your Vhasian duelist to parry with a flourish from royal fencing schools? Go ahead. Want to describe the eerie silence of a Valewood ruin when searching for clues? Perfect.

Flavor enriches narrative and makes the world feel real. It doesn't change mechanical outcomes, but it defines the *how* and the *why*. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate. Mechanics determine success or failure; flavor determines the story we tell about it.

A Guide for Veterans: Fate's Edge in a Nutshell

If you're experienced with other RPGs, here's a quick translation of how **Fate's Edge** handles common concepts:

Traditional RPG Concept	Fate's Edge Approach
Ability Scores & Skills	Attributes (Body, Wits, etc.) + Skills (Melee, Lore, etc.) form a dice pool.
Skill Checks	Roll Attribute+Skill pool. Count successes (6+). Compare to DV. Any 1s give GM SB.
Hit Points / Health	Harm Track for injuries. Fatigue for exhaustion. Consequences are narrative and mechanical.
Combat Rounds	Fiction-first. Actions resolved by narrative timing, not rigid initiative.
Spell Slots / Mana	Magic uses the same core system. 1s generate SB. Powerful spells may require extra time or risk.
Saving Throws	Roll Attribute+Skill to resist (e.g., Body+Resolve vs. poison).
Experience & Leveling Up	Gain XP through play. Spend to increase Attributes/Skills, buy Talents, or acquire Assets. Growth is player-directed.

The key difference is a consistent, unified mechanic applied across all challenges, focused on narrative outcomes.

1.7 Begin the Journey

Your role is a privilege and a creative challenge. You are a facilitator, a fan of the players, and the keeper of a world that will challenge and surprise them. Trust the rules to handle tension, trust your players to drive the story, and trust yourself to weave it all together.

Now, take a breath. Shuffle the deck. Let the dice fall.

It's time to guide the edge of fate.

Chapter 2

Running the Game: Core Procedures

2.1 How to Think in Fate’s Edge

Running **Fate’s Edge** is less about adjudicating difficulty and more about managing momentum. Your primary job is not to block success, protect outcomes, or simulate realism—it is to **frame pressure, track consequences, and let the fiction move forward**.

If you catch yourself asking “How hard should this be?” you are already one step behind. Instead ask:

- What is at stake right now?
- What happens if this goes wrong?
- What pressure is already in play?

The rules exist to answer those questions—not to replace them.

2.1.1 The Core Loop (In Practice)

Every meaningful action follows the same simple loop:

1. **Player declares intent and approach.**
2. **You state Position and set any relevant Clocks.**
3. **The roll resolves the moment.**
4. **You apply consequences and update the fiction.**

Do not search for the “right roll.” If the action matters, the procedure applies.

2.1.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt, trust the fiction. The system will follow. Fall back on these defaults:

- **DV:** 3
- **Position:** Controlled
- **Consequence:** Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure
- **Clocks:** One short clock tied to the scene

Escalate only when the fiction demands it.

2.1.3 What You Are *Not* Doing

You are *not*:

- calling for rolls to gate progress
- inflating difficulty to “challenge” the players
- protecting NPC plans from disruption
- hiding information behind unnecessary checks

If the players act decisively, the world must respond decisively.

2.1.4 What You *Are* Doing

You *are*:

- stating Position clearly and confidently
- letting partials move the story forward
- spending Story Beats to make failure interesting
- allowing success to create new problems

The game works best when nothing stalls.

2.1.5 A Useful Reframe

Think of each scene as a **pressure engine**:

- Dice create outcomes
- Clocks track fallout
- Story Beats fuel escalation
- Boons reward risk

Your job is to keep that engine turning—not to decide where it ends.

Let the procedures do the work. Your attention belongs on the fiction.

2.2 Optional Initiative Procedures

Fate's Edge uses **narrative initiative** by default: the GM frames spotlight based on the fiction. However, some tables prefer more structure, especially during complex combat. The following optional procedures are compatible with the core rules.

2.2.1 When to Use Structured Initiative

Consider structured initiative when:

- Combat involves six or more participants.
- Players want a clear, rotating turn order.
- The table enjoys tactical positioning and resource management.
- You mix groups with different speeds or reaction times.

Even with structured systems, prioritize the fiction: an ambusher still acts first.

2.2.2 Option A: Popcorn Initiative

Each round, the player who just acted chooses who goes next (friend or foe). The GM may veto unrealistic skips (e.g., an archer at Far acting before the enemy in Close).

IX Step Procedure	
1	Determine first actor by fiction (ambush, fastest PC, etc.).
2	That character takes their full turn.
3	After their turn, they choose any other character who has not acted this round to go next.
4	Repeat until all have acted.
5	End of round: last actor chooses first actor of the next round.

2.2.2.0.1 GM Guidance Use popcorn initiative to reward clever positioning. Enemies will naturally gang up on vulnerable PCs if players always choose foes – that's fine. If the table feels unfair, limit choice to “adjacent in fiction” (e.g., only those within Near range).

2.2.3 Option B: Side-Based Initiative

All player characters act together, then all enemies act together (or vice versa). Order within the side is negotiated by players.

IX Step Procedure	
1	Determine which side has surprise or narrative advantage. That side acts first.
2	All members of that side take their turns in any order (players decide).
3	All members of the other side take their turns.
4	Repeat.

2.2.3.0.1 GM Guidance Best for large combats (10+ combatants). To avoid “alpha strikes,” separate enemy groups into two initiatives (e.g., “archers” and “berserkers”) that act on different counts.

2.2.4 Option C: Speed-Based Slots

Each character rolls a die (e.g., 1d10 + Wits) for initiative. Higher scores act first. Ties go to the PC, or roll off.

IX

Step Procedure

-
- 1 At combat start, each player rolls 1d10 + Wits (or other attribute).
 - 2 The GM rolls once for each distinct enemy group (or individually for bosses).
 - 3 Order all participants by score highest to lowest.
 - 4 Act in that order.
 - 5 After each full round, optionally re-roll to reflect changing conditions.
-

2.2.4.0.1 GM Guidance Familiar to traditional players. Use a visible tracker (whiteboard, index cards). Re-rolling each round adds chaos but slows play slightly.

2.2.5 Mixing Narrative and Structured Initiative

Even with a structured system, override it when fiction demands. Examples:

- A PC triggers a trap mid-round → they act immediately, then initiative resumes.
- An enemy surrenders → remove them from the order; do not skip a player’s turn.
- A character is delayed (e.g., climbing a wall) → they act at end of round regardless of score.

Always state your override clearly: “The bridge collapses—Kaelen, you react first. Everyone else, hold your action.”

2.2.6 Recommendation for New GMs

Start with **narrative initiative** for the first 2–3 sessions. Once players are comfortable with Position and DV, introduce **popcorn initiative** for combat. Reserve side-based or speed-based for large, tactical fights. The best system keeps the fiction moving.

2.3 Standard Rule: Player-Managed Modules

This rule makes each player the primary steward of their character-facing trackers (*modules*). It keeps table pace high, reduces hidden bookkeeping, and clarifies when mechanical thresholds trigger. The GM retains authority over world-facing clocks, faction fronts, and major narrative consequences.

2.3.1 Scope (What Counts as a Module)

Player-managed modules are any **character-facing** clocks, counters, or discrete states on a single character sheet:

- **Obligation** (per Patron or Symbol)
- **Corruption Clock** (Cantor)
- **Leash** (Summoned spirit strain) and **Spirit Bond Clock**
- **Repertoire Clock** (Cantor) or similar progression clocks
- **Asset States** (Maintained / Neglected / Compromised / Shattered)
- **Scene Counters** explicitly tied to a PC (Exposure, personal Buff/Debuff durations)

Not included: GM story resources (global **Story Beats**), location/faction clocks, and mystery/doom fronts.

What Players Track (at a Glance)

11X

Module Owner Tick / Change Triggers (examples)

Obligation (by Patron) Player Invoke/Push/ritual text; Invoker *Borrowed Grace*; cracking a Symbol; bargain costs.

Corruption Clock Player Cantor Push; Resonant Rite; GM spends a Beat tied to the PC's occult actions.

Leash (Summoning) Player Harm to spirit; commands against nature; split focus; crossing [WARD] (DV = Cap).

Spirit Bond [4] Player Shared victories, mutual aid, meaningful attempts (once/session/type).

Repertoire [6] Player Learn a new unique Song/rite-as-song; practice milestones.

Asset State (Symbol) Player Maintenance/downtime checks; *Crack the Seal* → Compromised; breakage → Shattered.

2.3.2 Core Principle

Players **immediately** mark their own modules when a rule says “mark +X” or a trigger fires. Threshold effects resolve as soon as reached.

2.3.3 Player Duties

1. **Mark on Cue.** When you Invoke a Rite, Push, spend/clear per rules, or a trigger fires, update your module *now*, not later.
2. **Declare Thresholds.** If marking fills a clock or crosses capacity, say so aloud; thresholds resolve before the scene proceeds.
3. **State Ownership.** Keep per-Patron Obligation tallies distinct; track each Symbol's state.
4. **Keep It Visible.** Use a tracker the GM and table can see (sheet boxes, index cards, or shared digital).

2.3.4 GM Duties

1. **Spot-Check.** At need, ask any player: current Obligation by Patron, Corruption segments, Leash state, Asset states.
2. **Enforce Thresholds.** When a player reports a threshold, apply standard effects *immediately*.
3. **Own the Fallout.** Patron intrusions, faction reactions, front clocks, and major narrative consequences remain GM authority.

2.3.5 Standard Thresholds & Effects

2.3.5.0.1 Obligation Capacity

$$\text{ObligationCapacity} = \text{Spirit} + \text{Presence}$$

- **Over Capacity:** Mark +1 **Fatigue** per segment over capacity.
- **Over 2× Capacity:** Clear all Fatigue, mark +1 **Harm (Stress)**, and a **Patron Intrusion** occurs (GM frames on-theme demand/complication).

2.3.5.0.2 Corruption Full When a **Corruption Clock** fills:

- Apply the last-Patron **benefit & burden** to the PC (and any listed followers/retainers).
- **Reset** the Corruption Clock to empty.
- If the player chooses **Embrace Corruption**, convert the current Patron theme into a permanent boon/curse (see full rules).

2.3.5.0.3 Leash Full (Summoning) When the **Leash** fills:

- The spirit acts once to its nature, then **departs** (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Leash Capacity: $Cap + Spirit$ segments. (Cap is the outsider's tier: 1 for Lesser, 3 for Greater.)

2.3.5.0.4 Symbol State (Invoker)

- **Maintained** → normal function.
- **Neglected** → GM may impose +1 DV to related rites.
- **Compromised** (e.g., *Crack the Seal*) → instant resolution per rules; mark extra Obligation; repair in Downtime or pay 1 XP.
- **Shattered** → unusable until replaced or ritually restored.

2.3.6 Table Procedure (90-Second Loop)

2.3.6.0.1 Start of Session Players read out: per-Patron Obligation totals, Corruption segments, standing Asset States, and any personal clocks at 3+.

2.3.6.0.2 End of Scene Quick pass: “Any marks?” Players tick modules from scene events. If a threshold triggers, resolve now.

2.3.6.0.3 Downtime Players apply clears (service, contrition, purification, study) to their own modules. GM verifies any costs or fiction.

2.3.7 Disputes & Order of Operations

If two marks land simultaneously, apply them in the **least advantageous order for the acting character**, unless a rule specifies otherwise. The GM is final arbiter.

2.3.8 Accessibility & Tools

Use highly visible trackers: bold boxes on sheets, poker chips for segments, or a shared per-Patron Obligation table. Keep modules at-a-glance to minimize interruption.

2.3.9 Worked Micro-Examples

- **Invoker Rites Twice:** Vessa Invokes two different Patrons. She marks each Patron's Obligation separately. Hitting capacity with Patron A causes Fatigue; Patron B stays below.
- **Cantor Pushes:** Jorel Pushes a Song (mark +1 Corruption). That fills his clock; he gains last-Patron boon/burden immediately, then resets to 0.
- **Summoner Clash:** Kestra's Cap 3 elemental takes Harm and crosses a [WARD]; she ticks her Leash twice. On fill, the elemental flares once and departs.

The Core Loop: Your First 10 Games

Start here for your first session! Ignore advanced systems until comfortable.

1. Player states Goal & Action (Attribute + Skill)
2. GM sets simple DV (2–5)
3. Player rolls. Count Successes (6+)
4. GM consults Outcome Matrix. **Ignore Boons for now. Use simple complications on Partial/Miss.**

Once comfortable, add: Boons | Story Beats | Clocks

First Game Scenario: The Sunstone Tower

Premise: The party is hired to infiltrate the ruined Sunstone Tower and retrieve a magical sunstone before rival treasure hunters do. This scenario uses a limited rules subset perfect for beginners.

- **Ignore for this scenario:** Boons, Corruption, intricate magic subsystems, detailed Follower/Asset upkeep.
- **Focus on:** Core dice pool, Success/Partial/Miss outcomes, Position, Clocks.
- **Character Setup:** Use pregenerated characters or create simple ones with 20 XP and 2–3 clear hooks.

GM Prep in 10 Minutes

Sunstone Tower Prep Checklist

- Name 3 NPCs: hirer, rival delver, tower spirit (or echo).
- Write 1 sentence for each scene: Approach, Interior, Sunstone Chamber.
- Create 2 clocks: **Guardian Alert** [4] and **Tower Collapse** [6].
- Decide 1 twist: rival arrives early, tower shifts, or sunstone is not what it seems.

Scene 1: The Approach

Lane Marker: Skill Challenge with a Clock

GM Focus: Practice calls for DV and Partial outcomes. For this intro, tick the **Guardian Alert** [4] clock on a Partial or Miss.

The tower stands on a cliffside. Players must navigate three challenges:

- Cross the crumbling bridge (Athletics) – DV 3
- Scale the cliff face (Athletics/Strength) – DV 4
- Sneak past the stone guardians (Stealth) – DV 3

Guardian Alert Clock [4]: Each Partial or Miss advances the clock by 1. If filled, guardians activate and pursue; treat them as a single *Tower Guardian* threat with a simple [4] Harm track.

Scene 2: The Tower Interior

This scene teaches **Position** and **environmental stakes**.

- **Dominant:** “You have the high ground on the crumbling staircase, looking down on the patrol.”
- **Controlled:** “The hallway is dark but quiet. You can take your time, but there might be traps.”
- **Desperate:** “The floor gives way beneath you as you lunge for the door!”

How to Set Position in Play

- **Listen First:** Hear the player’s intent and approach. What are they actually doing in the fiction?
- **Assess the Situation:** Consider leverage, opposition, time pressure, exposure, and consequences. Ask: *How forgiving is the world right now?*
- **Assign the Position:**
 - **Dominant:** Clear leverage, surprise, or overwhelming advantage.
 - **Controlled:** Stable; mistakes are recoverable.
 - **Desperate:** Exposed, rushed, cornered, or facing serious danger.
- **State It Clearly:** Say it out loud before the roll. “*This is Desperate. If it goes wrong, the consequences will be serious.*”

Reminder: Position is a statement of risk and consequence, not a reward or penalty. It frames what failure *means*.

Scene 3: The Sunstone Chamber

The chamber is collapsing as rival delvers close in. Use a simple [6] clock for the collapse. Each round, the clock ticks up by 1. On each Miss, advance it by an extra 1 segment.

- **Goal:** Retrieve the sunstone and escape before the clock fills.
- **On Fill:** The chamber seals. Escape requires a final, Desperate group action.

Lane Marker: One New Idea at a Time

Scene 1: Clocks *only*.

Scene 2: Add *Position*.

Scene 3: Combine *Clocks + Position*. Reserve Boons, Corruption, and advanced magic for later sessions.

2.4 Learning Through Examples

This section walks the same situation through multiple passes, adding one rule at a time. Use it as a mental template when you improvise.

Example 1: Core Loop Only**Example 1 – No SB, No Boons**

Lyra tries to sneak past a guardian in a narrow hallway. (Agility + Stealth = 5d10).

GM: normal risk, DV 3, Controlled Position.

Roll: 3, 5, 6, 7, 9 → 3 successes (6,7,9).

DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success**.

GM: “You slip past the guardian quietly. You’re in position behind it if you want to act.”

Example 2: Add Story Beats Only**Example 2 – Adding Story Beats**

Same situation. Lyra rolls 5d10: 1, 4, 6, 6, 8.

Successes: 3 (6,6,8). One 1 → 1 SB for GM.

DV 3 with 3 successes = **Success** with 1 SB.

GM spend (1 SB = Minor): “You get past the guardian, but your cloak snags and tears. The sound echoes – the next room has a –1 Position penalty for stealth checks.”

Example 3: Add Boons Only**Example 3 – Adding Boons**

Later, Lyra scales a loose stone wall (Athletics + Agility = 4d10). DV 3.

Roll: 2,3,4,5 → 0 successes = **Miss**.

GM awards **2 Boons**. “You slip and land hard, taking 1 Harm. Mark 2 Boons – you can use them later to turn the tide.”

Next attempt, Lyra spends 1 Boon to re-roll a die, turning failure into success.

Example 4: Putting It Together**Example 4 – SB + Boons + Position**

The party flees as the tower collapses. A crumbling staircase blocks the exit.

GM: “Desperate. DV 4 to get everyone across safely.”

Lyra leads, rolling 6d10 (Agility + Athletics + help): 1,2,6,7,7,9.

4 successes vs DV 4 = **Success**. 1 rolled 1 = 1 SB to GM. Desperate Position.

GM: “You all make it across, but the last step collapses behind you. I spend 1 SB: your exit path is gone. You’ll need a new way out.”

Lesson: Even on a success, SB let you bend the fiction toward drama without erasing the player’s win.

2.5 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Player states intent, Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** Based on narrative stakes.

3. **Establish Position:** Dominant, Controlled, or Desperate.
4. **Roll Pool of d10s.**
5. **Count Successes (6+) and Story Beats (1s).**
6. **Check Against DV** using Outcome Matrix.
7. **Apply Outcome:** Clean Success, Success with Cost, Partial, or Miss.
8. **Spend SB** for complications and twists.

2.5.0.0.1 Clean Success. The action succeeds as intended. No Story Beats generated unless specified. Fiction advances cleanly.

2.5.0.0.2 Success with Cost. Action succeeds but generates **Story Beats**. Success stands; cost is GM spending those SB, ideally applied to the inciting action or its immediate consequences.

2.5.0.0.3 Miss. Action fails and generates **Story Beats**. GM uses those SB to introduce complications, advance opposition, or shift the situation against the character.

2.5.0.0.4 Partial Success (GM Adjudication). A Partial indicates progress but not full resolution. How that manifests is determined by the GM, based on context, scale, and narrative stakes.

Partial results may:

- Improve the character's **Position** on a follow-up attempt
- Reduce the effective **DV** of the next roll
- Achieve the goal at reduced scale or limited duration
- Succeed fully but generate a **Story Beat** as cost or complication
- Reveal information or create a new opportunity instead of immediate resolution

2.5.0.0.5 Example: Lockpicking. A character picks a DV 3 lock.

- **1 success (Partial):** Lock loosens but not opened; character gains *Controlled Position* on next attempt.
- **2 successes (Strong Partial):** Lock opens – GM spends the generated **Story Beat** to upgrade to *Success with Cost* (lock jams behind them, or someone hears the click).

2.5.0.0.6 Guiding Principle. Partials represent *meaningful progress*. Convert progress into advantage, resolution, or complication, depending on what best serves the fiction.

Position Effects

IX

Position Mechanical Effect

Dominant May re-roll one failure (die < 6).

Controlled Default state; no re-rolls.

Desperate Must re-roll one success (die 6+), keeping second result.

Difficulty Ladder – Beginner Focus

IX

DV When to Use

-
- 2 Routine: clear path, no pressure, almost guaranteed.
 - 3 Default: mild challenge, some risk – use most often.
 - 4 Hard: serious opposition, bad angle, or strong resistance.
 - 5+ Extreme: major boss encounters or dramatic gambles.
-

2.6 Story Beats: The Engine of Drama

Every time a player rolls a 1, you gain Story Beats (SB). These are narrative tools, not punishments.

SB Spend Menu

IX

SB Cost Simple Complications

-
- 1 SB Minor: noise, distraction, small setback, lost gear.
 - 2 SB Moderate: alarm raised, new threat enters, lose advantage.
 - 3+ SB Major: reinforcements, scene shifts, stakes escalate.
-

2.6.1 Failing Forward with SB

- **On Clean Success:** Use SB to add texture. The hero wins, but something changes.
- **On Success with Cost:** The hero gets what they wanted *and* you spend SB to add further cost or threat.
- **On Partial:** Use SB to make the complication sharper.
- **On Miss:** Spend SB to escalate the situation.

Lane Marker: One Complication per Roll

When in doubt, spend SB on *one* clear complication instead of many small ones. Name it plainly – “Guard Alerted”, “Floor Cracked”, “Oath Owed” – and move on.

Be **aggressive** with Story Beats, but never arbitrary:

- Do not hoard SB – unused pressure is wasted momentum.
- Do not invent contrived consequences that ignore the fiction.
- Spend SB to *sharpen what already matters*, not to add noise.

A single, well-chosen complication should change the situation, not just decorate it.

2.7 Combat Made Simple

Combat uses the same core loop. The stakes are higher and more immediate.

Combat Quick Reference

- **Initiative:** No fixed order. Ask: “Who acts next?” Follow the fiction.
- **Actions:** Each turn, a character can move and take one meaningful action.
- **Position Matters:** Flanking or ambush → Dominant; surrounded or exposed → Desperate.
- **Use Clocks:** Track enemy morale [6], environmental dangers [4], and boss thresholds.

2.7.1 Three-Beat Combat Structure

When lost in a fight, fall back on three beats:

1. **Opening Exchange:** Establish where everyone is and what they want.
2. **Turning Point:** Spend SB or tick clocks to change the situation (reinforcements, terrain shifts).
3. **Final Gamble:** Make the last few rolls matter – higher DV, Desperate Position, or big rewards.

Example: SB in Combat

The party fights bandits on a collapsing bridge.

On a Partial, GM spends 2 SB: “You push them back, but the bridge loses another support. The *Bridge Collapse* [4] clock advances.”

Now every action is also about whether they escape in time.

2.8 Clocks & Fronts

Clocks are visual trackers for threats, progress, and looming changes. They keep pressure visible and shared.

2.8.1 Basic Clock Usage

- **Size:** [4] for small scenes, [6] for bigger problems, [8] for arcs.
- **Advance On:** Misses, certain Partials, or SB spends.
- **Name It:** “Alarm Raised [4]” or “Floodwaters Rise [6]” is better than a blank circle.

Beginner Clock Limits

- No more than 3 active clocks per scene.
- Only 1–2 clocks should matter to the current roll.
- Say out loud when you tick a clock and why.

2.8.2 Mini-Fronts for Short Arcs

A *Front* is a cluster of related clocks and threats.

- **Example Front:** “Rival Delves of the Sunstone Tower”
- **Clocks:** “Rivals Close In [6]”, “Tower Integrity [6]”, “Rival Reputation [4]”.
- Each time you spend SB, consider ticking one of these clocks.

2.9 Ready for More? Add These Systems

Once comfortable with the core loop, introduce these modules one at a time. Treat each as a new lane marker.

2.9.1 Boons

Boons reward players for pushing their luck.

- On **Miss**: Gain 2 Boons.
- On **Partial**: Gain 1 Boon.
- **Spend**: Re-roll a die, add +1 Effect, or seize a small advantage (GM-approved).

Start with *re-roll only*. Once players are comfortable, add the other options.

2.9.2 Advanced Magic

- **Basic**: Use simple Tag-based magic (single roll, single tag).
- **Intermediate**: Add Runekeepers after 2–3 sessions, when everyone understands SB and Clocks.
- **Advanced**: Introduce Invokers and ritual magic for groups that enjoy planning and complex payoffs.

2.9.3 Followers, Assets, and Domains

Add persistent resources when the group cares about territory, organizations, or long-term projects.

- Start with 1 simple Follower or Asset each.
- Tie them to clocks: “Caravan Reputation [6]”, “Temple Influence [4]”.
- Spend SB to threaten or complicate these resources.

2.10 Abstracting Time and Currency

Fate’s Edge uses **narrative time** and **abstract wealth** to keep the focus on story, not bookkeeping.

2.10.1 Narrative Time (Not Minutes)

Describe durations in narrative beats, not concrete minutes or hours. Use these units:

Narrative Unit	When to Use
A moment	One action, a heartbeat, a single exchange
Some time	A few minutes – picking a lock, searching a room
Significant time	Hours – a ritual, a short rest, a negotiation
Half a day	Morning to noon, dusk to midnight
A day	Dawn to dusk, including travel or major activity

2.10.1.0.1 Example: Instead of “It takes 20 minutes to climb the tower”, say: “It takes **significant time** – long enough for the patrol to pass and return.” That keeps pressure without a stopwatch.

2.10.2 Abstract Currency (XP as Coin)

Fate’s Edge abstracts most coinage and barter. Exceptional expenses, bribes, or lifestyle costs are handled through **Boons**, **Assets**, or **Story Beats** – not copper counting.

When a player needs to pay for something significant and has no relevant Asset or favor, they may

spend **XP**. Treat 1 XP as a substantial bribe, emergency fund, or major purchase.

When to Use XP for Coin

Appropriate uses:

- Bribing a corrupt official (2–4 XP)
- Outfitting a small expedition (1 XP per full kit)
- Buying a rare magical component (2–3 XP)
- Establishing a modest safehouse (4 XP, counts as Minor Asset)

Inappropriate uses:

Routine meals, lodging, or travel supplies (cover with narrative)
 Anything that would trivialize a previous asset purchase
 Repeated, low-stakes expenses

2.10.2.0.1 GM Guidance: Spending XP for coin should feel like a meaningful sacrifice, not a tax. Always ask: “Is this advancing the story?” If yes, allow it. If not, offer a different cost (a Boon, a Debt, a Story Beat). This keeps material concerns from derailing the narrative.

2.11 Session Flow: A GM Cognitive Checklist

Use this as a quiet mental script. You do not need to say any of it out loud.

2.11.1 Opening 10 Minutes

- Ask: “What does everyone want out of tonight?” (goal, vibe, focus).
- Recap 2–3 key facts and 1 unresolved clock.
- Ask each player: “What is your character worried about right now?”

2.11.2 During Play

- Before a roll: Name DV, Position, and stakes.
- After a roll: Say the outcome type (Clean Success/Success with Cost/Partial/Miss) first, then the fiction.
- Between scenes: Look at clocks. Ask, “Which one should move? What changes in the world?”

2.11.3 Closing 10 Minutes

- Ask: “What was your favorite moment?” (signals what to do more of).
- Note any clocks that reached halfway or full.
- Jot 2 bullet points: “Next time on Fate’s Edge...” as hooks.

Quick GM Cheat Sheet

- **DV Default:** 3 (adjust ± 1 for ease/difficulty).
- **Position:** Controlled (normal), Dominant (advantage), Desperate (risk).
- **SB Spend:** 1=minor, 2=moderate, 3+=major complication.
- **Max Clocks:** 3 per scene to avoid overwhelm.
- **Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make a ruling that keeps the story moving.

Remember: The goal is to tell an exciting story together. These rules are tools, not tests. Start simple, add complexity when ready, and keep lane markers clear: one new idea at a time, one clear

consequence per roll, and one or two clocks that really matter.

The GM Mindset: Three Guiding Principles

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Principle Guidance

1. Don't Fear Failure The dice are not your opposition—they are your collaborators. When unsure, ask: *“Does this create a more interesting story?”* If yes, lean into it. The system rewards bold GM decisions with momentum, not penalties.

2. Spend SB to Create Every Story Beat should open a new door, not close one. “The door slams shut” is weaker than “the door slams shut – but the echo draws guards closer.” Favor movement, pressure, and consequences over hard stops.

3. The Real DV Is in Stakes If a scene feels flat, raise the stakes – not the difficulty. Before the roll, be clear about what failure means. When players ask “What happens if I fail?”, answer honestly. That answer is where tension lives, not in higher numbers.

Encounter in Action: The Ambush at Raven's Ford

This example shows how the core systems—narrative initiative, Story Beats, Boons, Bonds, and damage—come together in play. The party consists of **Thane** (fighter), **Sariel** (rogue), and **Kestra** (mage).

Setup

The group crosses a rope bridge when two bandits attack from the far side. GM sets the scene:

“The bridge sways under your feet. Two crossbowmen take aim from behind a boulder. Thane, you’re closest to them. Sariel is mid-bridge, Kestra still on the near cliff.”

No initiative rolled. GM asks: “Who acts first?” Thane says, “I charge.” The GM agrees – he’s closest and has momentum.

Round 1 — Thane's Turn

Thane rushes the bandits. GM: “Exposed on the bridge, crossbows trained on you – Desperate, DV 3 to reach them before they shoot.” Thane rolls Body + Melee (6d10): 7,5,4,2,1,1 → two successes (7 only). One short → Miss.

2.11.3.0.1 Result: GM gains 2 SB (two 1s) and player gains 2 Boons. GM narrates:

“You make it halfway, but a bolt grazes your arm. Mark Harm 1. The bandits draw swords – they’re in Close now.”

Enemy Turn (No Roll)

Because Thane closed the distance, bandits “draw swords” as a consequence of his Miss. GM uses the 2 SB:

- **Spend 1 SB:** “The second bandit kicks a loose plank. The bridge lurches – everyone make Body + Athletics (DV 3) or be knocked Prone.”
- **Spend 1 SB:** “Sariel, your footing slips; your next action is Desperate.”

Sariel fails; she is Prone. Kestra succeeds.

Player Turn — Sariel Uses a Boon

Sariel stabs the nearest bandit from prone. GM: “Desperate, DV 3.” She rolls: no successes → Miss, gains 2 Boons (now has 2 total). Before GM narrates failure, she **spends 1 Boon** to re-roll one die. Re-roll comes up 6 → adds one success, turning Miss into Partial. GM: “You slash his leg – he drops to one knee, but your dagger is lodged. It’ll take a moment to free it.”

Bond Transfer

Kestra has a Bond with Sariel (“She saved me once; I owe her”). As a free action (Tier III+), Kestra **transfers 2 Boons** to Sariel. Sariel now has 3 Boons.

Kestra's Turn — Boon for Environmental Effect

Kestra uses magic to collapse part of the bridge behind the bandits. She has **Spellcraft** and [EARTH], [BREAK]. GM: “Controlled, DV 4. Spend a Boon to improve to Dominant?” Kestra spends 1 Boon (now Dominant, DV 4). She rolls successfully, generating 1 SB (a 1). GM spends that SB immediately:

“The bridge splinters – the bandits are isolated! But the shockwave also loosens the rope on your side. New Clock: Bridge Collapse [4].”

Damage not rolled. Bandits stranded – a fictional consequence.

End of Encounter

Sariel, with extra Boons, frees the dagger and finishes the wounded bandit (Clean Success). The other bandit surrenders. No enemy “damage” rolled: all consequences came from SB.

Chapter 3

Managing Resources

In **Fate's Edge**, resources are narrative levers, not inventory lists. From the last sip of water in sun-scorched wastes to the fragile loyalty of a Ykrul war-band, every resource tells a story, and every story demands its price. As GM, you are the keeper of these threads—the weaver of scarcity and abundance. This chapter shows how to manage the systems that fuel mortal ambitions and epic campaigns.

3.1 Supply Clock: The Pulse of Survival

The **Supply Clock** tracks the party's access to essentials: food, water, gear, and logistical support. It is a shared party resource—a narrative lever that tightens tension when characters are isolated, pursued, or cut off from civilization.

3.1.1 Supply Clock States

Supply Clock Conditions

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Segments Filled	Narrative Effects
0 (Full)	Well-equipped and prepared; no penalty.
1 (Low)	Minor complications: bland rations, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins.
2 (Dangerous)	Each character gains Fatigue 1 as scarcity takes its toll.
3 (Empty)	Severe penalties: starvation, dehydration, equipment failure imminent.

3.1.2 When to Advance the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock advances when the world turns against the party's preparations:

- Extended travel through hostile lands without proper provisioning (see Travel Framework).
- The GM spends **2+ Story Beats** on logistics failures or environmental hardships.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth.
- Failed **Survival** or **Craft** rolls related to hunting, foraging, or repair.

3.1.3 Clearing Supply Segments

The clock recedes when the party finds respite:

- Reaching civilization resets the clock to *Full*.
- A group **Survival** check (Wits + Survival, DV 2) in favorable conditions clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Successful provisioning (a good hunt, a discovered cache) can reduce segments.

3.1.3.0.1 Example. A week-long sea passage with uncertain winds. A failed **Navigation** roll causes the GM to spend 2 SB – filling two segments as supplies spoil. The party is now at *Low Supply*. A second failed roll fills another segment – *Dangerously Low*. Fatigue sets in. The sea gnaws at their endurance.

3.2 Fatigue: The Weight of the World

Fatigue represents the cumulative toll of journeying through a world that rarely offers comfort: exhaustion that seeps into bones, hunger that hollows cheeks, strain that clouds judgment.

3.2.1 Fatigue Effects

Each point of Fatigue worsens the character's **Position** by one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate). If already Desperate, each additional Fatigue instead imposes a **–1 die penalty** on all rolls. Penalties from Fatigue and Harm **stack**.

Fatigue Progression

IX

Fatigue Level	Effect
1	Position worsens one step (Dominant → Controlled → Desperate)
2	If already Desperate, –1 die; otherwise Position worsens
3	–2 dice (if already Desperate from Fatigue)
4+	Collapse, KO, or spiritual break (incapacitated)

3.2.2 Clearing Fatigue

Recovery requires genuine respite:

- A **short rest** (quiet watch, food/water) removes **2 Fatigue**.
- A **full night's rest** in safety removes **all Fatigue**.
- Fatigue cannot be removed while the party is at *Dangerous* or *Empty Supply*.
- Medical attention (**Presence** + **Medicine**, DV 2) during downtime can remove an additional 1 Fatigue.

3.2.2.0.1 Narrative note: Fatigue is not only physical – it can reflect mental strain, grief, or spiritual exhaustion. A failed ritual might leave a caster at Fatigue 2 from metaphysical backlash alone.

3.2.3 Fatigue → Harm Conversion

Each character has a Fatigue track equal to their **Body** attribute. When the track fills:

1. Increase **Harm** by one level (0→Harm 1, Harm 1→Harm 2, Harm 2→Harm 3).
2. Clear all Fatigue.

This conversion can occur multiple times in a scene. (See the *Player's Guide* for full Harm rules.)

3.3 Boons: The Currency of Resilience

Boons are narrative tokens earned by embracing risk. They reward *failure with opportunity* – the silver lining in clouds of defeat.

3.3.1 Earning Boons (GM Reminders)

- On a **Partial** (1 Boon) or **Miss** (2 Boons) with meaningful consequences.
- Through clever or risky roleplay that drives the story.
- Via bond-driven actions with intricate descriptions.
- At GM discretion for exceptional collaborative play.

Limit: At most **2 Boons** from failures per character per scene. Repetition of the same approach with the same stakes does not award additional Boons.

3.3.2 Boon Economy (Quick Reference)

- **Holding cap:** Maximum 5 Boons.
- **Carryover:** At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2 (excess lost).
- **Conversion:** Once per session during downtime, convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (max 2 XP per session via conversion).

3.3.3 Spending Boons (Player Options)

Players may spend 1 Boon to:

- Re-roll a single die (after seeing the pool).
- Activate an on-screen Asset.
- Improve Position by one step before a roll.
- Power certain Rites or abilities as described in their text.

3.3.3.0.1 Substituting Fatigue for Boons (Optional) If a player has no Boons remaining, they may substitute **1 Fatigue** for 1 Boon *once per scene*. This represents pushing through exhaustion for a last chance. The GM may veto if the fiction does not support it.

3.3.4 Anti-Fishing Measures (GM Guidance)

- **Once/Scene Cap:** At most 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.
- **Repetition Rule:** Same approach + same stakes in the same scene cannot award another Boon.
- **Position Gate:** *Dominant* tests with trivial fallout do not award Boons.

Design note: Boons reward narrative risk, not repeated failure.

3.4 Followers and Assets: Power Beyond the Self

Players can invest XP in **Followers** (on-screen allies) and **Assets** (off-screen resources). These are story agents with their own motivations and risks.

3.4.1 Followers: On-Screen Allies

Followers are bought with XP and tracked by a **Cap** (maximum assist bonus). Cost = Cap² XP; downtime 1–3 days to recruit.

3.4.1.0.1 Assisting in Scenes

- Assist dice equal $\min(\text{Cap}, \text{helper's relevant Skill})$.
- Total assist from all sources capped at **+3 dice** (the *Exceptional Coordination* talent allows +4 from one follower).
- Only one follower may assist a given action.

3.4.1.0.2 Follower Independent Actions Once per scene, **one** follower may take a small independent action (the party can use this ability only once per scene, not per follower). Examples:

- **Scout & Signal** – Change an ally's next action to *Dominant*.
- **Distract & Draw** – Reduce a threat/hunt/escape clock by 1 tick.
- **Fetch & Carry** – Move a small object through danger.

Cost: Mark **Exposure +1** or **Harm 1** on that follower.

3.4.1.0.3 Follower Upkeep and Risk

- Each downtime, pay XP equal to Cap **or** spend a scene tending the relationship.
- Neglect → follower becomes *Wary* (or *Seized* if already *Wary*).
- If the GM spends **2+ SB** on an action you take with assistance, they may mark Exposure or Harm on the follower instead of other consequences (fiction first).
- **Off-Screen Capability:** Once per downtime, a Cap 3+ follower can solve a significant problem but generates **1 SB** for the party (the GM describes the resulting complication).

3.4.1.0.4 Follower Conditions Followers track two meters:

Exposure – Attention, stress, narrative pressure.

Harm – Injury, trauma, damage.

State: *Maintained* (full) → *Neglected* (–1 die) → *Compromised* (unavailable).

3.4.2 Assets: Off-Screen Influence

Assets are titles, safehouses, spy rings, charters. They do not act in scenes directly but change the fiction between sessions.

Asset Tiers

IX

Tier Cost and Examples

Minor 4 XP (1 day) – safehouse, small shop, local contact.

Standard 8 XP (1 week) – noble title, spy ring, workshop.

Major 12 XP (1 month) – city license, fortress lease, regional network.

3.4.2.0.1 Using Assets

- **Off-Screen Effect:** Use once per session for free (the quiet work between adventures).
- **On-Screen Activation:** Spend 1 Boon to use the asset dramatically in a scene.

- **Downtime Activation:** Pay 2 XP or 1 Boon to activate an asset at campaign start or during downtime.
- The asset must have plausible scope for the intended effect.

3.4.2.0.2 Asset Upkeep Each downtime:

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Cost = $\max(1, \frac{\text{AcquisitionXP}}{3})$. Minimal effort.
- **Intensive (lower XP, more time):** Cost = 1 XP. Requires a dedicated downtime action with significant personal involvement.
- Failure to pay → asset becomes *Neglected* (or *Compromised* if already *Neglected*).

3.4.2.0.3 Asset Condition

Maintained – Full capability.

Neglected – –1 die when used; requires attention.

Compromised – Unavailable until repaired or recovered.

3.5 Terrestrial Patrons: Favours and Debts

Not every patron is a cosmic entity. Powerful mortals—nobles, crime lords, generals, merchant princes—can act as **terrestrial patrons**. They offer tangible aid (escorts, legal protection, supplies) in exchange for favours. Treat them as a **Debt Clock** [4].

3.5.1 How Terrestrial Patrons Work

When a character accepts a favour from a terrestrial patron, start a **Debt Clock** with the patron's name (e.g., "Prefect Marcellus's Favour [4]"). Mark one segment each time the character accepts a significant favour (e.g., a bribe, a military escort, access to a restricted archive). When the clock fills, the patron calls in the debt – a mission to be performed, a political favour, or a direct demand.

Refusing to honour the debt turns the patron into an enemy (or at least a reliable antagonist). The GM may advance associated *Crisis* clocks or introduce complications from the patron's faction.

3.5.2 Examples of Terrestrial Patron Debts

Sample Terrestrial Patrons

IX

Patron Typical Favours and Debt Trigger

Prefect Marcellus (Ecktorian commander) Grants safe passage, food, and a squad of guards. Debt: demand a dangerous mission behind enemy lines.

Censor Cassia (judicial authority) Offers legal immunity, archive access. Debt: require the party to expose a political rival.

Khatun Sarnai (Ykrul chieftain) Provides remounts, safe camp, steppe guides. Debt: demand a blood-price or a raid on a rival clan.

Tema (Vilikari merchant) Smuggles goods, offers black market contacts. Debt: require the party to protect a secret caravan.

3.5.3 Running Terrestrial Patrons

- Track each patron's Debt Clock on a visible handout.
- When a player asks for a favour, tell them the cost: "Marcellus will give you the keys to the armory, but that's worth one segment. Are you willing?"
- When a Debt Clock fills, the favour is due. Give the players a hook that fits the patron's personality and resources.
- If the party refuses, tick the associated *Crisis* clock or introduce a complication (e.g., loss of safe passage, arrest warrant, hired thugs).

3.5.4 Optional: Terrestrial Patron Reputation

Some campaigns may track a separate **Reputation Track** for each patron. High reputation grants better terms (more favours before the debt clock fills). Low reputation may cause the patron to demand immediate payment before offering any help.

3.6 XP Awards: Growth Through Choice

XP is earned through genuine engagement, not attendance. Use these guidelines at the end of each session.

XP Award Guidelines

IX

Award Range

Table Attendance	+2 XP
Major Objective Completed	+2–4 XP
Discovery / Lore	+1–2 XP
Hard Choice	+1–2 XP
Complication Spotlight	+1–3 XP
Bond / Flag Driven Play	+1–2 XP
GM Curveball	+0–3 XP

3.6.1 Milestones

At the end of a major story arc:

- +8–12 XP to all players.
- +2 XP bonus to one player for a signature moment of the arc.

3.7 Campaign Resources: Mandate and Crisis

Two campaign-level clocks track the party's influence and the world's resistance.

3.7.1 Mandate Clock (0–6)

Tracks the party's public legitimacy.

- **High Mandate:** Allies seek them out, resources flow, doors open.
- **Low Mandate:** Suspicion, bureaucratic obstacles, support withers.

Advance the clock when the party gains renown (clean victories, public accolades) or loses face

(scandals, broken oaths).

3.7.2 Crisis Clock (0–6)

Tracks the opposition’s growing strength.

- **Rising Crisis:** Complications escalate, enemies grow bolder.
- **Managed Crisis:** Breathing room, opportunities to strike back.

Advance the clock when the party fails key objectives, ignores looming threats, or the GM spends SB on faction escalation.

3.7.2.0.1 Example. If the party brokers a peace treaty, advance *Mandate* by 1. If they assassinate a rival leader but leave evidence, advance *Crisis* by 1. When either clock reaches 6, trigger a major faction response (a summons, an assassination attempt, a public trial).

3.8 Combat Resource Management

In combat, resource management takes on desperate urgency.

3.8.1 Supply in Combat

- **Intense Combat:** GM may spend 1 SB to fill 1 Supply segment (arrows break, waterskins puncture).
- **Prolonged Engagement:** Each hour of sustained combat adds 1 Supply segment.
- **Ammunition Depletion:** Ranged weapons may run low, requiring scavenging actions (e.g., **Craft** roll to recover arrows).

3.8.2 Fatigue in Combat

- Characters apply Fatigue penalties as described in [3.2](#).
- Reaching Fatigue level 4+ during combat causes immediate collapse (incapacitated).
- Fatigue cannot be cleared during active combat.

3.8.3 Follower Combat Integration

- Followers assist using their Cap (see [3.4.1](#)).
- Spending **2+ SB** in combat can endanger an assisting follower (mark Exposure or Harm).
- Followers can take combat-relevant independent actions (cost: Exposure +1 or Harm 1).
- After a follower acts twice in a high-risk combat scene, mark Exposure +1.

3.8.4 Tactical Clocks

Tactical clocks represent persistent combat conditions that drain party resources.

Tactical Clock Effects

IX

Clock Resource Drain

Mob Overwhelm [6] Accelerates Supply depletion and Fatigue.

Fatigue Spiral [4] Accelerates existing Fatigue, makes each action harder.

Morale Collapse [6] Generates SB, reduces effectiveness.

Environmental Collapse [8] Creates new Supply and safety concerns.

3.8.5 Over-Stack Trigger

- If the party **enters** a scene with ≥ 3 **structural advantages**, the GM *may* apply Over-Stack once for that scene.
- Choose: start one obstacle at +1 DV, **or** bank +1 SB for the first Deck Twist.
- Over-Stack applies only to advantages held at scene framing, not those generated through play.

3.8.5.0.1 Examples of Structural Advantages Active buffs, favourable terrain (high ground, chokepoint), unused Follower Initiative, on-screen Asset activation, enemy disadvantage (surprised, trapped, outnumbered), ritual preparation that applies to the scene.

3.9 Narrative First: The Fiction Is the Ledger

In Fate’s Edge, arrows, rations, and waterskins are tracked only in the fiction that surrounds them. Mechanics engage only when those resources become scarce enough to matter. The focus remains always on **narrative tension** – the gnawing hunger, the fading light, the last arrow – not sterile bookkeeping.

3.9.0.0.1 Abstracting Coin and Time. Routine expenses and petty bribes are handled narratively (“You have enough coin from past jobs to cover a week’s stay”). For major expenses (bribing a corrupt official, outfitting an expedition, buying a rare magical component), players may spend **XP** in place of coin (1 XP = a substantial sum). Use the “XP as currency” rule sparingly; it should feel like a meaningful sacrifice, not a tax.

3.9.0.0.2 GM Reminder. When a player asks “Do I have enough arrows?” the answer is almost always “yes” until it becomes dramatically interesting to say “no.” Similarly, track Supply only when the party is isolated, pursued, or in a hostile environment. Let the world breathe with its own needs and abundances. And when the dice say the world pushes back against mortal plans – **listen to what they tell you about the price of ambition.**

Chapter 4

Magic and Backlash

In **Fate's Edge**, magic is not a clean art practiced in sterile towers. It is a **dangerous negotiation with forces beyond mortal comprehension**. As the GM, your role is to make magic **feel weighty, thematic, and alive with risk**. This chapter provides tools for adjudicating magical actions, managing consequences, and keeping the story at the forefront.

*For player-facing rules (spellcasting, Rites, Invoker symbols, Cantor songs, etc.), see the **Player's Guide**. This chapter focuses on your role as GM.*

4.1 The Role of Magic in Your Game

Magic in Fate's Edge is:

- **Consequential** – Every spell changes the fiction, for good or ill.
- **Risky** – Even success may generate Story Beats (SB) that you spend to complicate the moment.
- **Thematic** – Backlash should reflect the elements and Patrons involved.
- **Creative** – Reward inventive uses, but keep scope within the players' tier.

Your primary job is not to block magic, but to **frame costs, apply consequences, and escalate drama**. When a player wants to cast a spell, ask:

- What do they want to achieve?
- Which elements or Patrons are involved?
- What is at stake if it goes wrong?

4.2 Adjudicating Magic at the Table

Setting Difficulty Value (DV) and Position

Use the standard DV ladder (2–5+), but consider magical specifics:

[	
DV for Magic	IX
DV When to Use	

- 2 Routine cantrip, minor sensory effect, no opposition.
 - 3 Standard combat spell, small environmental change, contested but fair.
 - 4 Complex working, area effect, strong opposition, dangerous ritual.
 - 5+ Legendary magic, rewriting reality, binding a major Outsider.
-

4.2.0.0.1 Position for Magic

- **Dominant:** Caster has ritual preparation, rare components, or surprise.
- **Controlled:** Standard casting under normal conditions.
- **Desperate:** Caster is wounded, rushed, or in an anti-magic zone.

Position affects the severity of backlash (see 4.3).

Range Bands for Magic

Spells and effects have natural range limits based on their tags and fiction. Use these guidelines:

Range Band	Typical Spells
Close	Touch, personal aura, short cone.
Near	Same room/zone, thrown magics, most combat spells.
Far	Across a battlefield, line of sight without obstacles.
Absent	Ritual scrying, long-distance teleportation (requires setup).

4.2.0.0.2 Adjusting Range: A spell can be extended one band by increasing DV by 1, adding a SB, or requiring an extra action. Extreme range (e.g., scrying a distant city) should be a ritual, not a single roll.

Handling Creative Player Ideas

When a player tries something unexpected:

1. Listen to the description. What do they want to achieve?
2. Ask for the tags or elements involved. If none, help them add one.
3. Set DV and Position based on scope and risk (see ??).
4. Clearly state the stakes: “If you fail, the spell will backfire and also alert the guards.”
5. Let the dice decide, then spend SB to make the outcome interesting.

GM Ruling: Healing Magic

Mend restores Fatigue, not Harm. When a player uses a cantrip with only **Mend**, it removes 1 Fatigue. This is safe, fast, and low-risk.

Healing Harm costs more. To restore 1 level of Harm, the player must either:

- accept a **+2 DV modifier** on the spell, or
- use **Mend** with another tag (e.g., **Purify**, **Strengthen**).

The injury’s severity can raise DV further (e.g., Harm 2 → +1 DV on top). Requiring a second tag also makes healing a full two-action spell (Weave + Cast) unless the caster has a talent that compresses casting.

GM Tools: When a player heals Harm, you may spend any Story Beats generated by the

roll to introduce thematic complications (e.g., the wound leaves a scar, the healing draws supernatural attention, or the patient feels a strange hunger). This keeps magical healing dramatic, not trivial.

4.3 Story Beats and Backlash (GM Tools)

Every time a player rolls a 1 on a magical action, you gain Story Beats (SB) as described in 2.5. Spend them to create backlash – complications that fit the magic’s element and the fiction.

SB Spend Menu for Magic

[	
Spend SB on Magical Complications] IX	
SB Cost	Example Backlash
1 SB	Minor flare, eerie sound, brief sensory distortion, gear lightly scorched.
2 SB	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), spell draws attention, caster loses balance (Position –1).
3 SB	Patron omen, secondary target affected, magical feedback (Harm 1 to caster).
4+ SB	Reality warps – zone gains a temporary tag, Patron manifests a demand, a new threat appears.

Elemental Backlash Examples

Use these to color your complications:

Element	Sample Backlash
Fire	Smoke, heat exhaustion, small secondary fire, blinding flare.
Water	Flooding, slippery footing, emotional surge, dampness ruining supplies.
Earth	Tremor, dust cloud, immobilising stone grip, cracked floor.
Air	Sudden gust, deafening thunder, scatters important items, voice lost.
Fate	Prophetic nightmare, doors close, a crucial option disappears.
Luck	Allied misfortune, fragile success, random complication.
Life	Overgrowth, healing surge on enemy, parasitic plants.
Death	Ghostly whisper, chill, memory loss, premature decay.

Backlash Severity by Position

Position	Backlash Severity on Partial/Miss
Dominant	Minor – one SB complication, manageable cost.
Controlled	Moderate – 1–2 SB complication, temporary setback.
Desperate	Severe – 2–3 SB complication, lasting consequences or Harm.

4.4 Managing Obligation and Corruption

Players track their own Obligation and Corruption as described in 2.3, but you enforce thresholds and create consequences.

Obligation Overflow and Patron Intrusions

When a character exceeds their Obligation Capacity (Spirit + Presence):

- For each segment over capacity, mark 1 Fatigue (player does this).
- If they exceed **double capacity**, clear all Fatigue, mark Harm 1, and trigger a **Patron Intrusion** – a narrative demand or complication from the Patron.

4.4.0.0.1 Examples of Patron Intrusions

- The Patron appears in a dream: “Do this task for me, or else.”
- A rival servant of the same Patron arrives to collect a debt.
- The Patron’s mark becomes visible on the character’s skin, causing social trouble.
- A faction aligned with the Patron forcibly recruits the character.

Corruption as a Narrative Track

Corruption (Cantors, Pact-Whisperers) fills from pushes, resonant rites, and your SB spends. When the clock fills (see 2.3.5):

- Apply the Patron’s “benefit and burden” (see Patron tables in the **Player’s Guide**).
- Reset the clock to the character’s Tier minimum.
- If the player embraces corruption, give them a permanent thematic quirk (not a pure penalty).

4.5 Summoning (GM-Facing)

For full summoning mechanics, see the **Player’s Guide** (Pact-Whisperer). Here are your key responsibilities.

What to Watch For

- **Leash ticking:** Tick the Leash whenever the spirit takes Harm, acts against its nature, the summoner splits focus, or the spirit crosses a [WARD] (test DV = Cap).
- **Boon Finesse:** Players may spend 1 Boon once per round to clear 1 tick (before the Leash fills).
- **Quick Commands:** Simple orders (attack nearest, hold, fetch) do not cost the summoner’s action. Complex commands do.

When the Spirit Acts on Its Own

On a Miss, or when the Leash fills, the spirit acts once according to its nature before departing (or turning hostile). Use this to introduce a complication:

- A fire elemental sets the nearest structure ablaze.
- A shadow spirit whispers a secret to an enemy.
- A guardian spirit defends the wrong person.

Spirit Specializations (Quick Reference)

If a player develops a bonded spirit, you may grant one specialization from this list:

- **Combat:** +1 Harm melee, ignore first Harm on attacks.
- **Scout:** Stealthy; Cap 1 carries 2kg, Cap 3 carries 10kg.
- **Utility:** Simple tasks (carrying, opening doors).
- **Shield:** Interpose; convert Harm to Fatigue.

4.6 Cantors and Corruption (GM Guidance)

Cantors use Songs (Low Rites) with a Corruption Clock. Your main tasks:

- Track the Corruption Clock only when the player marks it (they manage it per [2.3](#)).
- On a fill, impose the last Patron's benefit & burden (from Patron tables in the **Player's Guide**).
- Spend SB to represent social fallout, Patron omens, or magical residue from their performances.

Inspire Chorus

Once per scene, a Cantor can shift all allies' Position +1 for one exchange. If they use it again in the same scene, they mark toward Corruption accumulation. This is a non-stacking aura; only the best shift applies.

Chorus Cults (Optional)

If a Cantor performs a Resonant Rite before 10+ witnesses, they may found a Chorus. This grants a minor follower benefit (see [2.9.3](#)), but they must mark Obligation each session they use it. If neglected, the cult fractures – you can introduce a rival sect or a scandal.

4.7 Ritual Magic (GM Advice)

Rituals are powerful but slow. Use them for effects that are too big for a single roll.

Setting DV for Rituals

- **Low Ritual (DV 3–4):** 10–15 minutes, affects a room or small area.
- **Standard Ritual (DV 4–5):** 30 minutes, affects a building or a scene.
- **High Ritual (DV 5+):** Hours, affects a district or narrative turning point.

Using Helpers

Helpers can reduce DV by 1 each (max –2) or absorb 1 SB of backlash. They must have relevant skills (Arcana, Lore, etc.). Interrupting a helper may disrupt the ritual.

Pacing and Interruption

If a ritual is interrupted, treat as a Miss on the casting roll (see [2.5](#)). You may also:

- Advance a doomsday clock.
- Summon an unexpected entity.
- Damage a needed component.

4.8 Psionics (Optional) – GM Sidebar

Adjudicating Psionics

Psionics is power without intermediaries – no Patrons, no symbols. As GM, ensure it feels precise yet costly.

Core Principles:

- Set DV by precision, not raw power. Clear intent = lower DV.
- Generate SB frequently – mental strain, sensory bleed, NPC suspicion.
- Respect consent: unwilling minds always resist.
- On Partial, offer hard choices: surface thoughts only, emotional truth without context.
- Distinguish from spellcraft: psionics excels at direct influence, not environmental change.

Example Backlash: headache, nosebleed, fleeting vision, target becomes aware of intrusion, caster loses focus (Fatigue 1).

4.9 Quick Reference Tables (GM Only)

Spend SB for Magical Complications

SB	Effect
1	Minor flare, noise, caster off-balance (–1 die next action).
2	Backlash harms an ally (Fatigue 1), draws attention, Position –1.
3	Patron omen, magical feedback (Harm 1), new clock (e.g., “Leaking Energy”).
4+	Reality warp, Patron manifestation, scene shifts (fire, flood, etc.).

Elemental Backlash Quick Picks

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)	Major (3+ SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks	Uncontrolled fire, explosion
Water	Slick floor, damp	Flooding, emotional storm
Earth	Dust, tremor	Collapse, binding
Air	Gust, ringing ears	Hurricane, deafness
Fate	Option closes	Prophecy becomes fixed
Luck	Small misfortune	A friend suffers the failure
Life	Overgrowth	Parasite, fever
Death	Chill whispers	A ghost manifests

Patron Intrusion Examples

Patron Type	Sample Intrusion
Everflame (Oath)	“Prove your purity – destroy that heretical text.”
The Traveler	“You must guide a lost soul to their destination.”
Inquisitor Prime	“Report any unsanctioned magic you witness.”
Malachai	“Curse someone weaker than you before dawn.”

Final GM Reminder

Magic is a narrative engine. Use Story Beats to create drama, not to punish. When in doubt, let the spell work and complicate the result. The world should react – but always in a way that keeps the story moving.

“Set the DV low. Spend SB to make the cost visible. Let the fiction lead.”

Chapter 5

Campaigns, Clocks, and Consequences

In **Fate’s Edge**, campaigns are not a sequence of disconnected adventures—they are **pressure systems**. Every choice the players make pushes on something: a faction, a threat, a relationship, a belief. Over time, those pressures accumulate, shift, and eventually *break*.

Your job as GM is not to hide this pressure—it is to **shape it, reveal it, and let the players decide where it lands**.

This chapter presents the core tools for doing that work: **Clocks**, **Consequences**, and long-term campaign structures. Used well, they create momentum without railroading and stakes without arbitrary escalation.

Clocks: Visible Pressure, Meaningful Choice

Clocks are the primary way Fate’s Edge tracks narrative pressure over time. They are not secret timers or surprise punishments—they are **shared context** that tells the table what is at risk and what is coming.

A clock answers one of three questions:

- **What is building?**
- **What happens if it completes?**
- **Who can affect it?**

If a clock does not clearly answer at least one of these, it is probably unnecessary.

The Three-Clock Guideline (Per Scene)

As a rule of thumb, a scene rarely needs more than **three active clocks**:

- **1 Immediate Clock** — What is about to go wrong *right now* (e.g., *Alarm Raised* [4], *Ritual Collapse* [6])
- **1 Situational Clock** — The pressure shaping player decisions (e.g., *Crowd Turns Hostile* [4], *Structural Failure* [6])
- **1 Long-Term Clock** — How this scene echoes forward (e.g., *Faction Retaliation* [8], *Corruption Advances* [6])

More clocks do not create more tension—they create **noise**. If players cannot name the clocks they

are pushing against, they cannot make meaningful choices.

Fantasy Subgenres and the Travel Rules

Fate's Edge is built from distinct regions, each with its own dominant **fantasy subgenre**:

- **Ecktoria** – Marble & Fire (political intrigue, legal drama, fall of empire)
- **Acasia** – Broken Marches (low fantasy, mercenary realism, border feuds)
- **Mistlands** – Bells, Salt, and Breath (folk horror, isolated communities, supernatural dread)
- **Valewood** – Empire Under Leaves (fairy tale, forgotten magic, nature's revenge)
- **Ykrul Steppe** – Storm on the Steppe (saga, nomadic honour, blood-price)
- **Kahfagia** – Wakes and Storm-Flags (nautical adventure, exploration, maritime trade)
- **Vhasia / Vittera** – Fractured Sun / Last Kingdom (courtly romance, chivalry, dynastic war)

When the party travels from one region to another, they cross between these subgenres. The **travel rules** (see Chapter 9 of the *Player's Guide*) are designed not merely to measure distance but to **blend these genres organically**. A journey from the mist-shrouded bogs of the Mistlands to the marble forums of Ecktoria should feel like turning the page from a folk-horror novella to a political thriller.

As GM, use the travel deck and regional prompts to:

- Introduce genre-appropriate complications (a wraith-touched fog in the Mistlands; a legal writ gone missing in Ecktoria).
- Allow the party to carry thematic elements from one region to the next (a curse from the Valewood might twist a courtly negotiation).
- Let the changing landscape reflect changing story stakes – travel is not a filler between adventures but a **genre-shifting engine**.

Why Hidden Clocks Rarely Pay Off

Hidden clocks often feel clever—but in practice, they weaken play.

- Players cannot meaningfully react to pressure they cannot see
- Surprise escalation feels arbitrary rather than earned
- The GM ends up carrying tension alone instead of sharing it

If a clock matters, **show it**. If it must remain unknown, foreshadow it through visible effects, rumors, or consequences—then reveal it as soon as the players can interact with it.

Exception: Hidden clocks work best when they are short-lived and revealed quickly (e.g., *Ambush Trigger [2]*), not as long-term campaign drivers.

Clocks Are Promises

Every clock you place on the table is a promise:

- When it fills, *something will happen*
- That outcome will be *consistent with what the players saw coming*
- The players had *opportunities to change the outcome*

Clocks do not exist to punish failure—they exist to **make consequences legible**. When players choose to ignore a clock, that choice should feel informed, intentional, and costly.

In Fate's Edge, tension is not hidden behind the screen. It sits on the table—ticking.

Mandate (0–6)

Mandate represents the table’s **public legitimacy and buy-in**—the measure of how much the world accepts the PCs’ authority, influence, or sacred mission. It is the currency of reputation in a world that remembers both triumphs and failures.

[	
Mandate Conditions and Effects] IX	
Mandate Level	Narrative Manifestations
0-2 (Low)	Suspicion dogs every step, doors remain closed, allies hesitate, every favor comes with strings attached
3-4 (Medium)	Respect is earned but conditional, some doors open while others require persuasion, trust must be continually maintained
5-6 (High)	Recognition precedes arrival, gates swing open unbidden, allies rally without question, reputation becomes a tangible asset

Crisis (0–6)

Crisis tracks the **opposition engine**—the rising tide of rivals, mounting pressures, and accumulating attrition that defines a challenging campaign. It shows how much the world pushes back against ambition and change.

[	
Crisis Conditions and Effects] IX	
Crisis Level	Narrative Manifestations
0-2 (Low)	Breathing room emerges, opportunities bloom like spring flowers, enemies regroup rather than attack
3-4 (Medium)	Pressure builds like gathering storm clouds, rivals make cautious moves, consequences become more immediate
5-6 (High)	Enemies strike with boldness born of desperation, clocks tick with alarming speed, the world tightens like a noose

Advancing the Clocks

At the end of each major scene, you may advance one or both clocks based on significant narrative developments:

- **Clean Loss:** A rival codifies their position or escapes with leverage that threatens the party’s standing
- **Public Cost Paid:** Extravagant feasts, declared holidays, or public penance that shifts perception
- **Asset Neglect:** Major assets degrade from inattention, signaling unreliability to potential allies
- **Evidence Shifts:** Immaculate reputations become scorched by scandal or revelation

Clock Evolution System

Campaign clocks should evolve as player actions change the world:

1. **Introduction** (0-2 segments): Threat becomes known
2. **Escalation** (3-4 segments): Threat gains momentum
3. **Crisis** (5-6 segments): Immediate danger to players/campaign
4. **Resolution** (7+ segments): Confrontation or transformation

Clock Relationships

Advanced campaigns benefit from clock relationships:

Supporting Clocks One clock's progress helps another (Plague Spread → Resource Scarcity)

Opposing Clocks One clock's progress hinders another (Public Support ↓ Crime Rate ↑)

Cascade Clocks One clock's resolution triggers another (War Ends → Reconstruction Begins)

Hidden Clocks Progress tied to player ignorance (Ancient Awakening while players focus elsewhere)

Calling or Forcing the Crown

The campaign reaches its crescendo when one of two thresholds is met—the moment when accumulated influence and mounting pressure collide in a final reckoning.

[

Finale Triggers and Conditions] IX

Finale Type **Conditions and Narrative Implications**

Player-Called Mandate 6 and Crisis 3—the party has earned the right to choose their moment of triumph

Forced Finale Crisis 6 regardless of Mandate—the world forces a confrontation that can no longer be avoided

Balanced Finale Both dials at 4-5—a tense equilibrium where victory and defeat hang in perfect balance

The Crown Spread: Seeding the Campaign

At **Session 0**, draw the **Crown Spread**—a five-card ritual that seeds the campaign's deepest themes, most dangerous rivals, and the very conditions of its ultimate resolution. This is not random chance but **oracular guidance** for the story to come.

Drawing the Spread

Draw one card for each of the five fundamental aspects of your campaign:

- **Spade:** The Crown Site—where destiny will be decided
- **Heart:** The Crown Rival—who stands between the party and their goals
- **Club:** The Crown Pressure—the relentless force that prevents complacency
- **Diamond:** The Crown Leverage—the advantage that can turn the tide
- **Wild:** The Hidden Force—the unknown element that will emerge when least expected

Interpreting the Spread

[

Crown Spread Interpretation Guide] IX

Card Position Interpretation Guidelines and Examples

Spade (Site) A fortress shrouded in mist? A shrine built on forgotten truths? A battlefield where history repeats?

Heart (Rival) A noble with hidden motives? A cult leader with apocalyptic visions? A spirit with ancient grievances?

Club (Pressure) An escalating curfew? A spreading plague? A resource shortage that turns allies into competitors?

Diamond (Leverage) Seasonal endorsement from powerful factions? A city license that grants unusual authority?

Wild (Hidden) Face card: hidden patron steps from shadows; Ace: the site itself becomes a 10-clock challenge

Example Spread: Spade = High-Mist Pass (Aeler territory); Heart = Margrave of Acasia (Face card—ambitious ruler); Club = Curfew (restricting movement); Diamond = Seasonal Endorsement (temporary authority); Wild = Hidden Patron (Face card—mysterious benefactor or foe).

Seasonal Evolution Framework

The Crown Spread elements should evolve through seasonal phases:

Winter (Establishment): Root themes take hold, initial conflicts emerge

Spring (Growth): New elements sprout, alliances form, complications multiply

Summer (Climax): Peak conflicts, major revelations, critical choices

Autumn (Harvest): Consequences manifest, legacies established, new seeds planted

Expanding Drawn Elements

When a Crown card's theme becomes central to your campaign:

1. **Deepen the Concept:** Add layers to the initial interpretation
2. **Introduce Variations:** Create related but distinct elements
3. **Connect to Other Elements:** Tie it to other Crown aspects
4. **Evolve the Stakes:** Raise the personal and cosmic implications

The Finale Procedure

When the Crown is called, run the three-beat finale that brings the campaign to its narrative climax:

1. **Reckoning:** Defend or sanctify the record of accomplishments. Draw upon the Rival's established motives. Place the Pressure rail that will drive the scene forward.
2. **Crossing:** Stage the kinetic rail (Escape/Hunt/Hazard) that threatens to end the scene prematurely if not managed carefully.
3. **Coronation:** Use the Diamond Leverage to sign, seal, or swear the oath that cements the campaign's legacy.

Twist Collision (Finale Clause)

Exactly once, when the Rival's Spade Twist contradicts their Club Belief, the table chooses:

- GM gains +1 SB to complicate matters, or
- Players reduce two ticks total across the active rails, gaining breathing room.

Legacy Conversion: Epilogue

After the Finale, each PC draws 2 cards and answers epilogue prompts by suit. Then convert campaign elements into lasting legacy:

- **Major Asset** → **Institution** (12 XP): A safehouse becomes a school, a spy ring becomes an intelligence service
- **Seasonal Endorsement** → **Doctrine Rider** (4 XP): Temporary support becomes permanent policy
- **Follower (Cap 3+)** → **Stationed NPC** (0 XP): Loyal companions become custodians of the new order
- **Rival** → **Fixture**: Surviving adversaries become recurring elements of the setting's fabric

Character Arc Management

Help players develop meaningful character growth through the legacy process:

1. **Establishment**: Define character's current state and potential conflicts
2. **Development**: Create opportunities for growth and choice
3. **Crisis**: Present challenges that test character's core beliefs
4. **Resolution**: Allow meaningful transformation based on choices

The Clockwork Engine: Tracking Tension

Clocks are the pulsating heart of tension in Fate's Edge. They represent ongoing conditions, threats, or progress toward objectives in a visible, tangible way that everyone can track and anticipate.

Types of Clocks

[

Clock Types and Their Purposes] IX

Clock Type Purpose and Typical Segment Count

Travel Clocks Track progress through dangerous journey legs (4-10 segments). *See note on blending fantasy subgenres above.*

Tactical Clocks Represent ongoing combat conditions like morale or fatigue (4-8 segments)

Campaign Clocks Track long-term pressure and influence (Mandate 0-6, Crisis 0-6)

Scene Clocks Specific to immediate situations like chases or disasters (4-6 segments)

War Clocks Large-scale conflict tracking like supply lines or morale (6-10 segments)

Clock Creation Guidelines

Creating effective clocks requires thoughtful design:

1. **Announce Clearly:** Always tell players what each clock represents and what fictional events cause it to advance.
2. **Logical Triggers:** Clock advancement should follow naturally from player actions and world events.
3. **Visible Progression:** Use physical tokens or visual aids so everyone can see tension building.
4. **Meaningful Consequences:** When clocks fill, the consequences should change the story in significant ways.

Clock Advancement Rules

Story Beats drive clock progression in measurable ways:

- **1 SB:** Minor advancement (1 segment)—a small but noticeable step forward
- **2-3 SB:** Moderate advancement (2 segments)—significant progress or escalation
- **4+ SB:** Major advancement (3+ segments) or filling smaller clocks entirely
- **Multiple Clocks:** Distribute SB across relevant clocks rather than overfilling one

Creating New Clocks

When existing clocks resolve or become less relevant:

- Identify emerging themes from recent sessions
- Consider player actions that created new tensions
- Look for unresolved consequences from major choices
- Evaluate faction shifts and new power dynamics

Campaign Combat Integration

Extended conflicts and war-level events require special handling to maintain narrative tension while scaling the mechanical scope appropriately.

War Clocks

Large-scale conflicts are tracked through persistent war-level clocks that represent strategic realities:

[	
War Clock Examples] IX	
War Clock	Strategic Implications and Triggers
Supply Lines (8)	Logistics and reinforcement flow; advances when routes are cut or resources dwindle
Morale (6)	Troop effectiveness and desertion risk; advances after defeats or poor conditions
Political Support (6)	Civilian and noble backing; advances when scandals emerge or costs mount
Strategic Position (8)	Control of key locations and routes; advances when territory is lost or gained

Faction Combat

When player factions engage in large-scale conflict, the rules adapt to maintain both narrative coherence and mechanical consistency:

- **Follower Armies:** Cap 5 followers can represent military units with distinct capabilities
- **Asset Leverage:** Off-screen assets provide strategic advantages like intelligence or supply
- **Campaign Clock Impact:** Major battles significantly shift Mandate and Crisis dials

Threat Ecosystem Design

Create interconnected threats that respond to player actions:

Threat Categories

Threat Categories] IX	
Category	Characteristics
Personal	Directly targets PCs/friends
Social	Affects communities/organizations
Cosmic	Universal/supernatural scope

Threat Evolution Matrix

	c	c	c	c	
	Response	Ignore	Oppose	Negotiate	Join
Weakens	Grows stronger	Splits/retreats	Seeks allies	Absorbs influence	
Strengthens	Spreads corruption	Escalates conflict	Offers better deal	Demands loyalty	
Transforms	Changes nature	Reveals true form	Shows hidden agenda	Offers power	

Faction Dynamics System

Faction Relationship Tracking

Track faction attitudes on a -3 to +3 scale:

- 3 Enemy** Actively working against player interests
- 2 Hostile** Will cause trouble when possible
- 1 Unfriendly** Suspicious and unhelpful
- 0 Neutral** Indifferent to player actions
- +1 Friendly** Helpful when convenient
- +2 Supportive** Actively assist player goals
- +3 Ally** Will sacrifice for player interests

Faction Clocks

Each major faction can track:

- **Influence** (0-6): Power and reach in the region
- **Stability** (0-6): Internal cohesion and resources
- **Agenda Progress** (0-8): Advancement toward faction goals
- **Player Relations** (-3 to +3): Attitude toward player characters

Between Sessions: The GM's Sacred Trust

Between game sessions, the Game Master undertakes crucial preparation that transforms good games into unforgettable campaigns. This quiet work is the foundation upon which epic stories are built.

Mandatory Preparation

[Between-Session Checklist] IX	
Task	Description and Guidelines
Campaign Clock Updates	Advance Mandate/Crisis based on session outcomes. Track developments that affect long-term trajectory
Complication Debt	Calculate starting SB: banked SB (max 2) + character complications + asset complications
Thread Management	Review active complication threads. Ensure no more than (Tier + 1) active threads per scene
Resource Tracking	Update NPC statuses, faction relationships, and world conditions based on player actions

Session Planning

Prepare the following elements with an eye toward pacing and player engagement:

- **Scene Preparation:** Design scenes with appropriate SB spending budgets (standard: 12 SB max, climactic: 16 SB max, session: 20 SB total)
- **Complication Hooks:** Develop 3-5 potential complications connecting to player backgrounds and campaign themes
- **Tactical Considerations:** Prepare combat, social, and exploration challenges with appropriate difficulties
- **Deck Preparation:** Ensure Consequences Deck is ready with cards appropriate for expected complication types

Reactive Preparation

Prepare for player creativity without scripting outcomes:

Situation Templates

Create flexible frameworks rather than fixed scenes:

Social Encounter Key NPCs, potential conflicts, information stakes

Exploration Challenge Environmental hazards, discovery rewards, time pressure

Combat Scenario Opponent capabilities, tactical elements, victory conditions

Mystery Investigation Clues, red herrings, revelation triggers

Improvisation Framework

When players surprise you:

1. **Identify Core Elements:** What must remain true for story coherence?

2. **Assess Player Investment:** What aspects do players care about?
3. **Find Narrative Hooks:** How can new elements connect to existing story?
4. **Apply Mechanical Logic:** What rules support this development?
5. **Maintain Momentum:** How to keep the story moving forward?

XP Award Calculation

Between sessions, calculate XP awards that reflect both accomplishment and engagement:

[XP Award Guidelines] IX		
Award Type	Description and Typical Value	
Table Attendance	+2 XP for participating in the shared story experience	
Major Objectives	+2-4 XP for achieving significant story goals that advance the campaign	
Discoveries	+1-2 XP for uncovering important information or hidden truths	
Hard Choices	+1-2 XP for making difficult decisions with meaningful consequences	
Complication Spotlight	+1-3 XP for engaging meaningfully with complications and setbacks	
Bond/Flag Play	+1-2 XP for roleplaying that emphasizes relationships and character depth	
GM Curveball	+0-3 XP for adapting well to unexpected developments and surprises	

Campaign Pacing

Session Energy Management

Vary session intensity to maintain engagement:

High Energy (2-3 sessions): Major conflicts, climactic scenes, critical choices

Moderate Energy (3-4 sessions): Character development, investigation, relationship building

Low Energy (1-2 sessions): Downtime, recovery, preparation, world exploration

Arc Structure Guidance

Multi-session story arcs benefit from clear structure:

1. **Introduction** (1-2 sessions): Establish stakes and hook players
2. **Development** (2-4 sessions): Complications multiply, alliances form
3. **Climax** (1-2 sessions): Major confrontation, critical choices
4. **Resolution** (1 session): Consequences, new status quo

GM Guide: Position as Narrative Leverage

Position is the GM's most powerful tool for calibrating narrative tension without altering core mechanics. It's not a mechanical bonus—it's your narrative compass.

Position as Narrative Guidance

Position tells you how to frame the scene, not how many dice to roll. The mechanical effect remains consistent across tiers (re-rolling one die), but what this means grows with your campaign's scope:

- **Tier I:** Position frames personal stakes—does the character live or die?

- **Tier III:** Position shapes regional outcomes—how much influence does the character have?
- **Tier V:** Position reshapes reality—what will the world look like after this moment?

5.0.1 How to Scale Position Without Bloat

- **At Tier I:** Position is life and death. A shift from Desperate to Controlled means "You escape with your life."
- **At Tier III:** Position is about influence. A shift from Controlled to Dominant means "The city's fate hangs on your decision."
- **At Tier V:** Position is world-shaping. A shift from Desperate to Controlled means "The universe holds its breath as you decide the world's fate."

5.0.2 What Position Means for GM Decisions

When to Use Position: Always, but the weight grows with tier.

- **Tier I:** Position guides how close the character is to capture or death
- **Tier III:** Position guides how the city responds to the character's actions
- **Tier V:** Position guides how the world reshapes around the character

5.0.3 Position and Narrative Momentum

Position is your guide to pacing and narrative flow. The same Position shift means different things at different tiers:

- **Tier I:** A shift from Desperate to Controlled means "You've bought time to think"
- **Tier III:** A shift from Controlled to Dominant means "The city rallies behind your cause"
- **Tier V:** A shift from Desperate to Controlled means "The world bends to your will"

5.0.4 What Not To Do

- **Don't add mechanical bonuses** (e.g., +1 die at Tier III, +2 dice at Tier V)
- **Don't treat Position as a tactical tool**—it's a narrative compass, not a combat modifier
- **Don't make Position the focus**—it's a means to frame the narrative, not the end goal
- **Don't let Position dictate the story**—use it to guide your narrative decisions, not determine outcomes

Warning: Don't Inflate Difficulty Values

As characters grow more competent, it can be tempting to raise Difficulty Values (DV) to “keep them challenged.” **Resist that urge.**

Why DV inflation breaks the game:

- Higher DV reduces the frequency of Partial and Misses, which are the primary sources of **Boons**. Fewer Boons means players have fewer resources to spend on re-rolls, assets, and creative moves – their competence becomes a liability.
- It punishes players for investing in high Attributes and Skills, making their growth feel pointless.
- It forces you to inflate DVs again next session, creating an arms race that only hurts player satisfaction.

How Fate's Edge naturally scales challenge:

1. **Higher die pools already generate more Story Beats (SB).** A seasoned character rolls 8–10 dice, so each action produces multiple 1s on average. Those SB are your primary tool for complicating success – spend them to introduce twists, escalate clocks, or trigger Patron intrusions.
2. **Success becomes cleaner, so Boons become scarcer.** As players miss less, they earn fewer Boons. That scarcity is the real resource pressure at high tiers – not higher DVs.
3. **Tags and critical skills already inflate DV when appropriate.** A [DANGEROUS] tag (e.g., [TELEPORT]) adds +2 DV by itself. Complex rituals or large-scale effects naturally call for DV 4–5. Trust the tag system.

What to do instead:

- Use **Clocks** to add time pressure and branching consequences.
- Spend SB aggressively – a single roll can tick multiple clocks or trigger a Patron demand.
- Worsen **Position** when the fiction calls for danger, not DV.
- Introduce **tactical complications** (reinforcements, environmental shifts, hostage situations).

Golden rule: *Let the dice pools grow. Let the SB flow. Let the Boons become precious. Your game will scale naturally.*

5.0.5 GM Mindset

- **At Tier I:** Focus on personal stakes—how does Position affect the character's survival?
- **At Tier III:** Focus on regional impact—how does Position shape the city or region?
- **At Tier V:** Focus on world-shaping consequences—how does Position reshape reality?

Position is not a progression system. It's a lens through which you frame the narrative. The mechanics stay consistent so the story can grow as large as your imagination allows.

Golden Rule: Never add mechanical bonuses to Position. Instead, deepen the narrative weight:

- **Tier I:** "Position shows whether you live or die"
- **Tier V:** "Position shows how the world bends to your will"

Boon Economy Across Tiers

Boons are the players' primary resource for re-rolls, asset activations, and narrative leverage. Their availability changes dramatically as characters advance – and that shift is by design, not an accident.

How Tier Changes Boon Generation

At **Tier I–II**, characters have small dice pools (typically 4–6 dice). They roll Misses and Partial successes often, each of which awards 2 or 1 Boons respectively. A low-tier party might earn 6–10 Boons per scene.

At **Tier IV–V**, characters roll 8–10 dice. They rarely Miss, and Partial successes become the most common outcome. Boons become scarce – a high-tier party might earn only 2–4 Boons per scene.

Why This Works

- **Low-tier characters need the help.** Their small pools produce unreliable results; Boons give them a cushion to re-roll failures and activate assets.
- **High-tier characters must rely on skill, not luck.** With huge pools and reliable success, they no longer have a safety net of Boons. Every re-roll or asset activation is a meaningful choice.
- **The scarcity creates tension.** At high levels, spending a Boon on a re-roll means you cannot activate your spy network later. The resource becomes a strategic lever, not a crutch.

GM Guidance: Don't "Fix" the Scarcity

Some GMs see high-tier players struggling for Boons and want to invent new ways to award them. ****Resist.****

The scarcity is intentional. If you inject extra Boons, you remove the resource pressure that makes high-tier play interesting. Instead, let players adapt:

- They will rely more on their high Skills and clever positioning.
- They will use Boons on critical moments, not routine rolls.
- They will activate assets only when they truly need them.

Optional Rule: The Nine's Boon

Some tables enjoy a little extra luck at any tier. This optional rule adds a small, controlled drip of Boons without breaking the high-tier economy.

The Nine's Boon (Optional)

When you roll a natural **9** on any die (before re-rolls), you gain **1 Boon**, provided you have not already earned the maximum of **2 Boons from failures this scene**. This Boon is generated immediately and may be spent normally.

Why 9? The number nine is laden with threshold significance in Fate's Edge – the un-rung bell, the un-poured cup, the step that is not counted. This rule leans into that theme without overlapping with the critical success of a 10.

Impact on high-tier play: Even with large dice pools, a 9 is a specific face, not a statistical flood. At 10 dice, you will see roughly one 9 per roll on average – still less Boon generation than low-tier Misses. The rule adds a tiny safety valve without restoring the low-tier abundance.

Note: This Boon counts toward the per-scene limit of 2 Boons from failures. If a player has already earned 2 Boons from Misses or Partial failures this scene, rolling a 9 grants nothing extra.

Advanced Mechanical Integration

Corruption System Evolution

Tier-Based Corruption

As characters advance, corruption becomes more complex:

Tier I-II Surface-level changes, minor abilities, social consequences

Tier III-IV Fundamental transformations, significant powers, world impact

Tier V+ Mythic alterations, reality-bending abilities, cosmic significance

Corruption Narratives

Connect corruption to character themes:

- **Power Corruption:** Strength gained at cost of morality
- **Knowledge Corruption:** Wisdom gained through forbidden understanding
- **Survival Corruption:** Endurance through dark adaptation
- **Love Corruption:** Connection maintained through dangerous bonds

Asset and Follower Management

Portfolio System

Organize holdings for easier management:

Economic Trade routes, businesses, investments

Political Titles, contacts, influence networks

Military Retainers, fortifications, strategic positions

Intelligence Informants, research facilities, magical resources

Asset Evolution

Allow significant holdings to grow in importance:

1. **Establishment:** Basic functionality and limited scope
2. **Development:** Expanded capabilities and regional influence
3. **Mastery:** Major impact and strategic significance

4. **Legacy:** Permanent change to campaign world

Campaign-Specific Tools

Custom Background Creation

Background Template

Create setting-specific character origins:

1. **Origin Story:** Where and how the character was raised/formed
2. **Core Skills:** Two skills naturally supported by background
3. **Key Relationships:** One ally and one rival with ongoing significance
4. **Cultural Elements:** Unique customs, languages, or traditions
5. **Obligations:** What the character owes to their background
6. **Privileges:** What the character can expect from their background

Background Integration

Connect backgrounds to campaign themes:

- Identify background elements that relate to current threats
- Create opportunities for background knowledge to provide advantages
- Develop complications that arise from background obligations
- Allow backgrounds to evolve based on player choices

Regional Customization

Culture-Specific Mechanics

Adapt core systems to different cultural contexts:

Aeler (Stone-Born) Emphasize engineering, contracts, and infrastructure

Lethai (Wood Elves) Focus on nature, seasonal cycles, and root-law

Ykrul (Steppe Folk) Highlight mobility, honor, and spatial reasoning

Kahfagia (Sea Folk) Stress navigation, weather, and maritime law

Regional Threat Adaptation

Modify threats to fit different environments:

- **Desert:** Heat, sandstorms, water scarcity, nomad conflicts
- **Mountains:** Avalanches, altitude, isolation, territorial disputes
- **Forest:** Predators, maze-like paths, spirits, resource competition
- **Urban:** Politics, crime, overcrowding, infrastructure failure

Advanced Storytelling Techniques

Thematic Consistency

Maintain campaign atmosphere through consistent elements:

Sensory Details

Create immersive environments:

- **Visual:** Lighting, colors, architectural styles, movement patterns

- **Auditory:** Ambient sounds, speech patterns, musical traditions
- **Olfactory:** Scents, cooking aromas, industrial odors, natural fragrances
- **Tactile:** Textures, temperatures, weather effects, material qualities

Cultural Patterns

Establish consistent social behaviors:

- Greeting customs and social hierarchies
- Conflict resolution methods and legal systems
- Economic practices and trade relationships
- Religious beliefs and spiritual practices

Moral Complexity Framework

Create nuanced ethical dilemmas:

Dilemma Structure

Effective moral choices require:

1. **Clear Stakes:** What is gained or lost by each choice?
2. **Genuine Conflict:** Why isn't there an obviously right answer?
3. **Personal Investment:** How does this affect the characters directly?
4. **Lasting Consequences:** What changes based on the decision?

Consequence Types

Ensure meaningful outcomes:

Immediate Resolve within session (character fates, instant reactions)

Ongoing Affect future sessions/campaign (reputation, political fallout)

Character Personal growth/trauma, relationship changes

World Setting permanently changed (Silkstrand's fate, Choir's influence)

Narrative First: The World Remembers

Campaign design in Fate's Edge is not about railroading players along predetermined paths—it's about **responding to player choices** with consequences that accumulate like stones in a river, gradually shaping the flow of the narrative itself. Let the world shift in response to their actions. Let factions rise and fall based on their allegiances. Let the dice sing the song of a universe that reacts.

And when the Crown is finally crowned—when the last card is played and the final clock ticks to completion—let the echo of that moment be heard across the entire Amaranthine, a testament to stories well-lived and consequences fully earned.

Remember: Your preparation between sessions is the quiet magic that transforms random encounters into meaningful episodes and mechanical challenges into memorable stories. The investment in this sacred trust pays dividends in player engagement, narrative coherence, and the creation of campaigns that will be remembered long after the final dice have been rolled.

5.0.6 Quick Start Campaigns

5.0.6.1 The Sunstone Gambit

Campaign Overview: A medium-difficulty introduction to Fate's Edge core mechanics set in the politically charged environment of Acasia.

Campaign Elements:

- **Duration:** 4-6 sessions of 3-4 hours each
- **Tier Range:** 0-60 XP progression
- **Themes:** Political intrigue, ancient mysteries, personal honor
- **Key Locations:** Ruined Sunstone Tower, Silkstrand marketplace, Acasian border fortresses

Session Breakdown:

1. **Session 1 - "The Commission":** Character introduction, initial briefing, first skill challenges
2. **Session 2 - "Crossing the Border":** Travel complications, introduction to regional politics
3. **Session 3 - "The Tower's Secrets":** Exploration challenges, first major combat encounter
4. **Session 4 - "Rival Claims":** Social maneuvering, second major conflict
5. **Session 5 - "The Sunstone's Price":** Climactic confrontation, moral dilemma resolution
6. **Session 6 - "Aftermath":** Character advancement, campaign consequences, setup for future adventures

Key NPCs:

- **Lady Cordelia Vex:** The enigmatic patron who commissions the retrieval
- **Captain Thorne Blackwater:** Rival treasure hunter and former legionary
- **Keeper Aldric:** Ancient guardian spirit bound to the Sunstone Tower
- **Magistrate Ysabel Marr:** Silkstrand official caught between competing interests

5.0.6.2 Modular Session Structure

Session Components:

- **Opening Check-in** (10 minutes): Player mood, character updates, session goals
- **Continuity Bridge** (5 minutes): Recap previous session's key events and outcomes
- **Main Action Block** (90-120 minutes): Central adventure content with multiple encounter types
- **Character Development Segment** (20 minutes): Advancement opportunities, relationship building
- **Closing Reflection** (10 minutes): Session highlights, preview next session, address concerns

Flexible Timing Options:

- **Short Session** (2-3 hours): Focus on single encounter with brief character development
- **Standard Session** (3-4 hours): Balanced mix of action, roleplay, and advancement
- **Extended Session** (5-6 hours): Multiple encounters with deep character progression

5.0.7 Tier-Appropriate Design

5.0.7.1 Tier I-II Campaigns (0-90 XP)

Scope: Local or regional focus with personal stakes

- **Story Structure:** 3-5 session arcs with clear beginning, middle, and end

- **Threat Level:** Individual antagonists, local factions, environmental hazards
- **Character Growth:** Focus on establishing character identity and core relationships
- **World Impact:** Changes to immediate surroundings with limited broader consequences

5.0.7.2 Tier III Campaigns (91-150 XP)

Scope: Regional to national influence with expanding responsibilities

- **Story Structure:** 6-10 session arcs with branching possibilities and long-term consequences
- **Threat Level:** Organized adversaries, political conspiracies, supernatural entities
- **Character Growth:** Development of leadership skills and organizational influence
- **World Impact:** Noticeable changes to regional politics and major faction dynamics

5.0.7.3 Tiers IV-V Campaigns (151+ XP)

Scope: National to continental influence with world-shaping potential

- **Story Structure:** Multi-arc campaigns spanning 15+ sessions with legacy elements
- **Threat Level:** Cosmic forces, legendary adversaries, existential threats
- **Character Growth:** Transformation into mythic figures with lasting influence
- **World Impact:** Fundamental changes to world order and historical trajectory

5.1 Scaling Threats

5.1.1 Threat Evolution Framework

Phase 1: Introduction

- Present threat through minor incidents or rumors
- Establish threat's capabilities and motivations
- Create initial player investment through personal connections

Phase 2: Escalation

- Increase threat's visibility and impact
- Introduce complications that raise stakes
- Force player responses that reveal threat's adaptability

Phase 3: Confrontation

- Direct engagement with threat's full capabilities
- Present moral or tactical dilemmas that test player growth
- Create opportunities for definitive resolution or transformation

5.1.2 Threat Customization by Tier

Low-Tier Adaptations:

- Reduce threat's scope and influence
- Simplify threat's methods and motivations
- Provide clear vulnerabilities and straightforward counters

High-Tier Adaptations:

- Expand threat's reach and resources

- Introduce complex motivations and hidden agendas
- Create multiple threat vectors and contingency plans

5.2 Branching Narrative Design

5.2.1 Consequence-Driven Branching

Immediate Consequences:

- Short-term changes visible within the same session or next session
- Direct results of player actions that alter immediate circumstances
- Examples: NPC reactions, environmental changes, tactical advantages/disadvantages

Extended Consequences:

- Medium-term changes that develop over 2-5 sessions
- Ripple effects that create new opportunities or challenges
- Examples: Faction reputation shifts, economic impacts, political realignments

Legacy Consequences:

- Long-term changes that persist throughout the campaign
- Fundamental alterations to the world that affect future storylines
- Examples: Major NPC deaths/births, territorial changes, technological/social advances

5.2.2 Branching Structure Types

Event-Based Branching:

- Different story paths based on specific events or discoveries
- Requires preparation of multiple potential scenarios
- Best for campaigns with predetermined major plot points

Choice-Based Branching:

- Multiple valid approaches to challenges with different outcomes
- Emphasizes player agency and creative problem-solving
- Requires flexible preparation and improvisation skills

Relationship-Based Branching:

- Story developments based on player interactions with NPCs
- Dynamic narrative that responds to relationship building
- Requires detailed NPC development and relationship tracking

5.3 Character Arc Planning

5.3.1 Defining Character Growth

5.3.1.1 Internal Arcs

Concept: Character development focused on internal transformation, beliefs, and personal growth.

Planning Framework:

1. **Starting Point:** Identify current character flaws, fears, or limiting beliefs

2. **Growth Direction:** Define what the character aspires to become or overcome
3. **Catalyst Events:** Plan key moments that will challenge and change the character
4. **Resolution Vision:** Envision the character's state at the end of their arc

Example Internal Arc - The Reluctant Leader:

- **Starting Point:** Fear of responsibility and doubt in personal abilities
- **Growth Direction:** Development of confidence and acceptance of leadership role
- **Catalyst Events:** Moments where others depend on the character, failures that provide learning opportunities
- **Resolution Vision:** Character who confidently makes difficult decisions for the group's benefit

5.3.1.2 External Arcs

Concept: Character development focused on external achievements, relationships, and worldly success.

Planning Framework:

1. **Goal Identification:** Define what the character wants to achieve in the world
2. **Obstacle Recognition:** Identify challenges that prevent easy achievement
3. **Progression Milestones:** Plan key accomplishments that mark advancement
4. **Success Definition:** Determine what constitutes fulfillment of the character's goals

Example External Arc - The Avenging Scholar:

- **Goal Identification:** Restore family honor and expose corruption that destroyed their lineage
- **Obstacle Recognition:** Powerful enemies, lack of evidence, social stigma against their family
- **Progression Milestones:** Gathering evidence, gaining allies, public exposure of wrongdoing
- **Success Definition:** Justice served and family name cleared in the eyes of society

5.3.2 Integrating Arcs with Campaign

5.3.2.1 Campaign Alignment

Pre-Campaign Planning:

- Share character arc concepts with the GM during Session Zero
- Identify potential campaign elements that could support character growth
- Establish connections between personal goals and campaign themes

5.3.2.2 Ongoing Integration

Session-to-Session Development:

- Regularly assess character progress toward arc goals
- Seek opportunities to introduce arc-relevant challenges and experiences
- Adapt arc direction based on campaign developments and player interests

5.3.3 Measuring Progress

5.3.3.1 Narrative Milestones

Concept: Significant story moments that mark character development regardless of mechanical advancement.

Tracking Methods:

- **Journal Entries:** Regular character journal entries documenting growth and reflections
- **Relationship Changes:** Noting shifts in how NPCs perceive and interact with the character
- **Decision Points:** Recording important choices that demonstrate character evolution
- **Reputation Shifts:** Tracking changes in how the character is known in the world

5.3.3.2 Mechanical Milestones

Concept: Character advancement that supports and reflects narrative growth.

Tracking Methods:

- **Skill Development:** Improving abilities that align with character arc themes
- **Talent Acquisition:** Choosing new abilities that support character growth direction
- **Asset Accumulation:** Gaining resources that enable character goals
- **Reputation Building:** Developing relationships and influence that advance character objectives

Chapter 6

Advanced GM Techniques

This chapter assumes you have mastered Fate’s Edge core rules. It offers tools for GMs running ****experienced groups and higher-tier campaigns (Tier III+)****. If you are new to the game, start with earlier chapters.

6.1 Advanced Story Beat Management

Story Beats (SB) are your primary tool for escalating tension. At high tiers, you will have more SB to spend – but also more narrative threads to manage.

Spending SB Across Multiple Threads

Instead of pouring all SB into one complication, distribute them across several active clocks or fronts (see 2.8). A scene might have:

- *Alarm Raised [4]* – advances from noise or failed stealth.
- *Rival Closing In [6]* – advances from delays or loud magic.
- *Patron Attention [8]* – advances each time a Rite is invoked.

Each Miss or Partial can tick one or two small clocks instead of a single big setback. This keeps pressure distributed and gives players multiple problems to solve.

Using SB to Advance Campaign Fronts

When a scene directly relates to a long-term front (e.g., a war, a spreading curse), spend SB to advance that front’s clock – even if the scene is otherwise a “success”. Example: The party defeats a cultist cell (clean success), but you spend 2 SB to tick *Cult Influence [6]* – their network still grows elsewhere.

Banked SB from Player Complications

Characters may start sessions with banked SB from unresolved complications (see 2.3). These count toward scene spending limits but should be spent on ****thematic complications tied to that character’s background or Patron****, not generic setbacks. This makes personal storylines matter.

Example: Cascade Spend

A single Miss generates 2 SB. The GM:

1. Spends 1 SB to advance *Alarm Raised [4]* by 1 (now 2/4 – guards are converging).

2. Spends 1 SB to advance *Rival Closing In* [6] by 1 (now 3/6 – rival scouts are spotted).
3. Both clocks are now half full – the scene’s tension doubles without a single “big” complication.

6.2 Mastering the Deck of Consequences

The deck is not just a randomizer; it is a **thematic engine**. Use it to keep complications fresh and unpredictable, even at high tiers.

Combining Draws (Suit Synthesis)

Draw up to 3 cards per SB spend (minimum 1, maximum 3). Synthesise a single twist from the combination of suits, not just the highest rank.

- **Hearts + Spades:** Emotional betrayal that leads to physical harm (“Your ally flees, and the portcullis drops on you.”)
- **Clubs + Diamonds:** Resource drain with magical backlash (“The ritual consumes your healing herbs and leaves a tainted scar.”)
- **Hearts + Clubs + Spades:** Social pressure plus resource loss plus injury – a crowd riots and loots your gear.

Using the Deck for Non-Linear Scenes

Draw a card to inspire flashbacks, montages, or off-screen events. Example: During downtime, draw a Clubs card – “A fire at your safehouse.” Instead of playing it, you narrate a short scene of the party arriving to find the aftermath. The deck becomes a prompt generator, not merely a roll-aftermath tool.

Custom Suit Tables

For a specific campaign or region, replace the default suit meanings with custom ones. Example – Shadow Court campaign:

- **Hearts:** Vows and obligations.
- **Spades:** Physical traps and barriers.
- **Clubs:** Political pressure and blackmail.
- **Diamonds:** Oaths and geasa.

This re-flavours the deck without changing its structure.

6.3 Advanced Travel and Genre Blending

Travel in Fate’s Edge is not filler – it is a way to **shift fantasy subgenres** as the party moves between regions. Use travel clocks (see Chapter 9 of the *Player’s Guide*) and regional decks to create a journey that feels like turning pages from one story into another.

Designing Travel Legs as Mini-Arcs

Each travel leg can have its own dramatic arc: setup (departure), complication (en route), climax (arrival under pressure). Use a 4–6 segment clock for the leg. When it fills, they arrive – but the manner of arrival (e.g., chased, exhausted, bearing a new ally) changes the next scene.

Genre Shifting Example

A journey from the **Mistlands (folk horror)** to **Ecktoria (political intrigue)** might have three legs:

1. **Leg 1 (Mistlands):** Fog, bells, a wraith that speaks in riddles. (Horror)
2. **Leg 2 (Borderlands):** A toll bridge, a corrupt clerk, a forged writ. (Low fantasy / crime)
3. **Leg 3 (Ecktoria outskirts):** A noble’s hunting lodge, a dinner invitation, a whispered plot. (Intrigue)

The travel deck for each leg should draw from the destination region’s themes – but the *complications* should reflect the transition.

6.4 Faction Grand Strategy

At high tiers, factions act as “campaign engines.” Build them with ****faction clocks**** that advance whether the players intervene or not.

Faction Clock Examples

- **War [8]** – Advances when battles occur or supply lines are cut.
- **Influence [6]** – Advances when allies are won or propaganda spreads.
- **Intrigue [8]** – Advances when secrets are uncovered or betrayals happen.

These clocks are ****visible to players**** – they see the war brewing, even if they cannot stop it alone.

Player Actions and Faction Clocks

When players act, they can tick a faction clock forward or backward. Example: Sabotaging a siege engine ticks *War* -1 (enemy’s clock) and ticks *Their Own Mandate* $+1$ (see 3.7.1). Document these changes openly. The world becomes a reactive board.

Running a “Faction Turn” Between Sessions

For a highly political campaign, between sessions you can:

- Ask players for their faction’s orders (e.g., “Send spies to the capital”).
- Roll a single die per order (Pass/Fail/Partial) using the faction’s relevant Asset (e.g., Spy Ring).
- Advance faction clocks accordingly.
- Start the next session with a brief “news from the front” segment.

This makes factions feel alive without heavy bookkeeping.

6.5 Designing High-Tier Custom Content

At Tiers IV–V, characters can reshape nations and realities. Custom content should grant ****narrative permissions****, not merely bigger numbers.

Epic Talents (12+ XP)

An epic talent might:

- Allow rewriting one line of a Patron’s Rite (changing its cost or effect).
- Grant a once-per-session “truth edit” – the GM must accept one factual change to the scene.
- Let a character invoke a Patron’s name to retroactively avoid a TPK (once per campaign, with heavy cost).

These are not combat bonuses – they change what kind of story is being told.

Assets for Ruling Nations

A Major Asset (12 XP) might be a kingdom. Its free use could be “order a levy” or “declare a holiday”. Its scene surge (1 Boon) could be “call in a noble favour” or “divert a river”. Such assets come with obvious upkeep (taxes, succession, rebellions) – and they can be threatened or lost.

Adventures for Demigods

At the highest tiers, stakes should threaten **concepts**, not just lives. Examples:

- A curse that erases the memory of a city.
- A war that will redraw the map for centuries.
- A Patron who will change the fundamental laws of magic.

Victory may not be guaranteed – but even failure should leave a permanent mark on the world.

6.6 Running Mythic Scenarios (Tiers IV–V)

At the apex of power, the game changes. Use these techniques to keep play grounded in choices, not points.

Handling Reality-Altering Magic

When a player attempts something cosmic (e.g., “I wish the volcano had never erupted”), do not say no. Instead, offer a **compromise**:

- “You can do it, but it will cost you your connection to this place – you will never return.”
- “It works, but for the remainder of the session, the world is unstable – every roll generates an extra SB.”
- “You succeed, but your Patron demands a permanent sacrifice – one of your Talents is erased.”

The effect happens, but the price is felt.

Player Agency at Cosmic Scale

At Tier V, every choice may erase an alternative timeline. Embrace this: let players narrate what they are saving (or sacrificing) when they act. Example: “I stop the ritual – but I let the rival escape.” That rival becomes a future problem.

Let the World Break

If the climax involves a collapsing reality, the battlefield itself can be a clock. Example: *Reality Fracture* [8]. Each time a major event occurs (a spell, a death, an oath), tick the clock. When it fills, the scene shifts – time loops, gravity reverses, or the characters meet themselves from another timeline.

6.7 Advanced Complex Scenarios

Heists: Player-Designed Plans

Instead of planning the heist for them, ask each player: “How does your character contribute to the plan?” Build a clock (e.g., *Heist Progress* [8]). Each player makes a roll using their chosen method (Stealth, Deception, Arcana, etc.). Success ticks the clock; failure adds complications (alarm, guard alerted). The GM spends SB from misses to introduce obstacles from the security system.

Mass Combat: Unit Clocks

Instead of rolling for every soldier, treat opposing armies as a single *War Clock* [8]. Player actions (command, sabotage, rally) tick the clock. When it fills, that side breaks or routs. Personal combat can happen in the same scene – but the mass conflict is abstracted to a single visible tracker.

Political Intrigue: Reputation as a Resource

Track a *Reputation Clock* [6] for the party in a given court. Social actions (gossip, favours, public deeds) tick it. When it fills, they become “trusted” – they can call in a major favour before the clock resets. But enemies also watch their rise, and may work to degrade the clock.

6.8 When to Say Yes, No, and Yes, But – Advanced Rulings

At high levels, players will attempt things that break normal bounds. Use these frameworks.

Compromise Solutions

Instead of a flat “no”, offer a ****scaled success**** with a cost:

- **Yes, but only for this scene.**
- **Yes, but you must mark a permanent Condition.**
- **Yes, but it will take longer – start a clock.**
- **Yes, but the GM gains 3 SB to spend on that effect.**

This keeps creativity alive while respecting the game’s tension economy.

Saying “No” Without Shutting Down

If a plan is impossible (e.g., “I kill the god with a single arrow”), explain why: “The god is not physically present; you would need to unmake its last shrine first.” Then offer a path: “If you find the shrine and perform a ritual, you could banish it – you’ll need to gather three relics.” Turn the “no” into a new arc.

Let the Dice Decide – But Hedge

For a truly impossible request, set an ****extreme DV (6+)**** and a ****Desperate Position****. If they succeed, they get a lesser version of what they wanted, or a temporary victory. This respects the dice while maintaining verisimilitude.

GM Golden Rule for Advanced Play

The mechanics are not a ceiling – they are scaffolding. Build taller stories with them, but never let them crush creativity.

Chapter 7

Enhanced GM Play

You have mastered the core rules. Now it is time to embrace a liberating truth: ****you are a player too****. Your role is not to serve as a passive rules engine or an adversarial obstacle. You are a co-creator of drama, a conductor of tension, and – most importantly – someone who deserves to be surprised, delighted, and engaged by the game.

This chapter reframes GMing as an active, playful role. It offers low-overhead techniques to build tension, handle player indecision, adjust difficulty on the fly, and give you a few light “game” elements to play with – all while keeping your own enjoyment at the centre.

7.1 The GM as Player: A Philosophy

Unlike a board game, where the GM enforces fixed rules, Fate’s Edge invites you to ****play to find out what happens****. You are not protecting a pre-written plot. You are throwing complications, asking questions, and reacting to player choices with genuine curiosity.

What Makes the GM’s Role Fun

- **Surprise:** When players invent a solution you never considered, celebrate it. Let it change the story.
- **Power with Purpose:** Your resources (SB, Threat Pool, clocks) are not weapons – they are narrative levers. Using them well feels satisfying.
- **Collaborative Discovery:** You do not know how the scene will end any more than the players do. That uncertainty is the game’s heartbeat.

What to Let Go

- **The need to be “fair” in every roll:** Fairness lives in the fiction, not the dice. It is fair that a desperate roll fails spectacularly.
- **The fear of “losing”:** You cannot lose. Your goal is to make the story memorable, not to defeat the players.
- **The obligation to have all answers:** Say “I don’t know – what do you think?” then build on their answer.

7.2 Playing with Story Beats

Story Beats (SB) are your primary resource. Think of them as ****dramatic currency**** – spend them to make scenes more interesting for everyone, including you.

Advanced SB Spends (For Your Enjoyment)

- **1 SB:** Ask a leading question – “You notice something odd about the guard’s uniform. What is it?” (Let the player invent a detail.)
- **2 SB:** Introduce a minor environmental hazard – a loose floorboard, a dripping pipe, a sudden draft. Describe it vividly.
- **3 SB:** Force a quick decision – “The door is closing. Stay and fight, or dive through?” (Watch them squirm – it is fun.)
- **4+ SB:** Reveal a hidden connection – “The bandit’s dagger has your family crest.” (Now you are as curious as they are.)

These turns SB from mere setbacks into narrative tools that engage players ***and*** surprise you.

7.3 A Light Game for You: Threat Pool (Optional)

If you want a small, fun resource to “play” with – a mini-game for the GM – use the ****Threat Pool****. It gives you a few extra points per scene to spend, without adding complexity.

How It Works

- Start each scene with **3 Threat points**.
- Threat points do not carry over between scenes.
- You may spend Threat points on the following options. Treat it as your own little bag of tricks.

[

Threat Pool Spend Options] IX

Cost Effect

-
- 1 Threat An enemy gains +1 die on its next action. (Feel the tension rise.)
 - 1 Threat Introduce a very minor environmental detail – creaking floor, flickering light, a distant scream.
 - 2 Threat An enemy acts immediately (interrupt initiative order once). (Surprise the players.)
 - 2 Threat Add a minor clock (e.g., *Fire Spreading [4]*) to the scene.
 - 3 Threat Introduce a new, weaker enemy (Cap 1–2). (Escalate when the fight needs a jolt.)
 - 3 Threat Force a player to re-roll a single die (their choice of which die).
-

Threat points are not a new economy – they are a simple pacing toy. Use them or ignore them; the game works fine either way. But when you use them, you are ***playing***.

7.4 Pacing and Tension Tactics (For GM Enjoyment)

The Three-Beat Scene Structure

For any important scene, aim for three emotional beats:

1. **Setup:** Establish stakes and environment. (Describe something evocative.)
2. **Clash:** Roll dice, spend SB, introduce complications. (This is where you get to be active.)
3. **Aftermath:** Resolve or escalate – but never leave a scene hanging. (Savour the outcome.)

If a scene drags, ask yourself: “What is the main question this scene answers?” Answer it, then move on. Your boredom is a sign to cut.

Using Clocks as Countdowns (Visible Fun)

Instead of saying “you have three rounds”, show a clock: *Reinforcements Arrive* [4]. Players see it tick. You get to watch them prioritise under pressure. It is a simple joy.

Ending a Scene Before It Drags

When the main conflict is resolved, cut. Do not play out cleanup unless there is remaining tension. “You defeat the bandits – the rest flee. What do you do next?” Move on. Your energy is precious.

7.5 Handling Player Indecision (Without Frustration)

Offer Two Clear Choices

Never give more than two obvious paths. “Do you sneak past the guard or try to bribe him?” A third option (“or wait”) is usually a stall. If they cannot choose, the world decides – the guard notices them. This keeps you from waiting.

Ask Leading Questions

Instead of “What do you do?” ask “Are you rushing in or staying back?” Framed choices keep momentum and reduce your cognitive load.

Use a Ticking Clock

If players hesitate, tick a clock. “While you argue, the fire spreads – *Flood* [4] advances 1.” They will act. You will feel the satisfaction of applied pressure.

7.6 Adjusting Difficulty on the Fly (For Smoother Play)

Lower DV Instead of Fudging Dice

If a challenge is too hard, reduce its DV by 1. The players never need to know. This is cleaner than ignoring a bad roll and preserves your credibility.

Offer a Devil’s Bargain

Instead of a flat failure, ask: “You can succeed, but something else goes wrong. What is it?” This turns failure into player-driven complication. You get to be surprised by their answer.

Add a Clock Instead of Raising DV

If a scene needs more tension, add a 4-segment clock (*Security Alert*) rather than increasing DV. Players see the clock and feel pressure, but the core roll remains fair. You get the tension without the maths.

7.7 Spotlight Management (Share the Love)

Rotate by Environment

In a quiet library, the scholar shines. On a battlefield, the fighter takes lead. Watch whose skills match the scene and give them first action. This keeps you engaged by varying who you interact with.

Use Bonds to Pass the Spotlight

Say: “You owe Marcus a debt. What do you do to protect him?” This directly engages a bond and moves focus. Bonds are your ally.

Quick Check-Ins

If one player is dominating, ask another: “While that happens, what is your character doing?” A simple question brings them back in. It also gives you a moment to breathe.

7.8 Using Failure to Advance the Plot (Make It Fun for You)

Fail Forward

A failed lockpick does not mean “nothing happens”. It means “the lock clicks, but loudly – a guard stirs.” The story moves. You get to introduce a new twist.

Failure Reveals Information

“You cannot pick the lock, but you notice the brand of a noble house – someone here has expensive tastes.” You just gave them a clue. That is progress.

Offer a Hard Choice Instead of Flat Failure

“You can force the lock, but your pick will break – you will not be able to open another door tonight.” Let the player choose. Watching them weigh options is half the fun.

7.9 Foreshadowing and Secrets (Reward Your Own Curiosity)

Show, Don’t Tell

Instead of “this place is dangerous”, describe: a bloody handprint, a cold draft, a whisper that stops when you enter. You are painting a mystery for yourself as much as for them.

Use SB to Plant Clues

Spend 1 SB to add a subtle detail: “You notice a torn piece of cloth on the window latch. It is a livery colour you recognise.” Now you have a thread you can pull later.

Reveal Secrets Through Play, Not Exposition

Do not recap lore; let players discover it via rolls, clues, and NPC dialogue. If they miss it, it stays hidden – or they can find it another way. You get to be surprised when they finally uncover it.

7.10 Running Cliffhangers (Your Dramatic Exit)

End a Session After a Miss or Partial

The dice just gave you a perfect cliffhanger. End there: “The door swings open – and you see her.” No further description. You get to enjoy the groans of anticipation.

Ask a Compelling Question

“The ritual completes. What happens to the city?” Write down the answer; start the next session with it. You have just outsourced a plot point – and their answer will inspire you.

Write Down the Cliffhanger

Keep a note – “Last thing: the door opened to reveal the queen’s double.” Read it aloud at the start of the next session. It builds continuity and makes you look organised.

7.11 Recovering from Bad Rulings (Gracefully)**Admit It Quickly**

“I ruled that incorrectly. From now on, we will do it this way.” Players appreciate honesty. Your ego is not at stake.

Offer a Retroactive Boon

If a bad ruling hurt a player, give them a free Boon. No need to retcon the past. You turn a mistake into a gift.

Only Retcon if the Game Breaks

If the ruling was minor, move on. If it invalidates a major plot point, say “Let’s rewind that scene – my mistake.” Then replay the last few minutes. Your players will understand.

7.12 Lightweight Faction Loyalty (Optional – For Your Sandbox)

Track faction standing on a simple ****–3 to +3 scale****. No dice, no complex tables.

- **–3:** Enemy – actively works against the party.
- **0:** Neutral – indifferent.
- **+3:** Ally – will sacrifice for the party.

Shift loyalty by ****1**** after major interactions (saved the faction, betrayed them, etc.). Display the number openly. That is it. You now have a living world with minimal effort.

7.13 Complication Trading (Player Choice, Your Delight)

When a player fails or partially succeeds, offer them a ****choice of complication****:

- “You fail to pick the lock. Does the noise alert a guard, or do you break your tools?”
- “You miss the shot. Does the arrow hit an ally, or do you lose your balance and fall?”

This keeps players engaged even in failure. You get to watch them choose their poison.

7.14 Cross-Cultural Synergy (Creativity Tip)

Encourage players to combine cultural elements from different regions. If they propose a clever mix (e.g., Aeler engineering + Kahfagian sailing = a faster ship), give them a ****+1 die**** or ****reduce DV by 1**** for that roll. You reward creativity, and you get to see the world come alive through their ideas.

7.15 Final Thought: You Are Playing Too

Do not forget that you are a player at the table. Use SB and the optional Threat Pool to have fun. Laugh at the unexpected outcomes. Be surprised by player choices. Celebrate their successes and your own clever complications.

Your enjoyment is as important as theirs. When you are having fun, the table feels it.

Now go run a memorable scene – and enjoy the ride.

“The best sessions are the ones where the GM walks away thinking, ‘I had no idea that would happen.’”

Chapter 8

Tier IV and V: Running Epic Adventures

As characters reach Tier IV and V, the game changes. The scope expands from local concerns to regional, national, or world-shaking events. This chapter focuses on how to run these epic tiers effectively, with special attention to how the game **naturally scales** through Boon scarcity – not inflated Difficulty Values.

8.1 What Changes at Tier IV–V

- **Scope:** Actions affect cities, nations, or the entire known world.
- **Consequences:** Failure can shift political borders, end bloodlines, or awaken ancient horrors.
- **Time:** Campaigns often span months or years, with downtime becoming a major phase.
- **Legacy:** Characters become legends – their deeds echo for generations.

The core mechanics remain the same. The difference is **weight** – every success and every failure reshapes the fiction in larger, more permanent ways.

8.2 Natural Scaling: The Boon Economy Does the Work

One of Fate's Edge's most elegant features is how it automatically scales difficulty without inflating numbers. At high tiers, characters have large dice pools (often 8–10 dice). They succeed more often and generate fewer Misses and Partial – the primary sources of Boons.

Boon Generation Basics (Reminder)

- **Miss (0 successes):** Gain 2 Boons.
- **Partial (0 < successes < DV):** Gain 1 Boon.
- **Clean Success (successes ≥ DV, SB = 0):** No Boons.
- **Success with Cost (successes ≥ DV, SB > 0):** No Boons.

Boons do not come from winning. They come from *struggling*.

Boon Availability by Tier (Typical)

Tier	Avg. Boons earned per scene	Typical use
I (0–40 XP)	2–3	Re-rolls, minor advantages
II (41–90 XP)	1–2	Re-rolls, asset activation
III (91–150 XP)	1	Critical rerolls, story shifts
IV (151–220 XP)	0–1	Rare, decisive actions
V (221+ XP)	0–1 (often 0)	Mythic choices only

Why This Works

- **Low-tier characters need the help.** Their small pools produce unreliable results; Boons give them a cushion.
- **High-tier characters must rely on skill, not luck.** With huge pools and reliable success, they no longer have a safety net.
- **The scarcity creates strategic depth.** At high levels, spending a Boon on a re-roll means you cannot activate your spy network later. Every Boon is a meaningful choice.

Do Not Increase Boon Awards

Resist the urge to give out extra Boons because players “look cool” or “rolled a 10.” The scarcity is intentional. It makes high-tier play feel tense and consequential. If you inject Boons, you remove the resource pressure that defines epic play.

Example: Tier I vs. Tier V

A Tier I rogue picks a lock (DV 3, 5 dice). She rolls a Miss → gains 2 Boons, re-rolls, succeeds. A Tier V master thief picks the same lock (DV 3, 10 dice). He rolls a Clean Success → no Boons. Later, he fails a critical roll to disable a ward – he has only 1 Boon left. He must decide: re-roll this roll, or save it for the escape. The tension is real.

8.3 Do Not Inflate Difficulty Values

A higher DV does not mean “more challenging” – it means “fewer Partials, fewer Boons, faster escalation.” At high tiers, players have large pools, but raising DV to 5 or 6 will starve them of Boons entirely and make failure feel arbitrary.

Scale Challenge With These Tools Instead

- **Clocks:** Add a 4–6 segment clock to the scene (*Palace Coup* [4], *Ritual Completion* [6]). Players see it tick.
- **Position:** Worsen Position when the fiction demands danger. A Desperate roll already re-rolls successes – that is plenty.
- **Consequences:** Use SB to add layered costs (see 2.6 and ??).
- **Faction Clocks:** Advance long-term threats (*War* [8]) regardless of player success in individual scenes (see 2.8).

When Is a Higher DV Appropriate?

Only when the *fiction* itself demands it: a god’s impossible ward, a lock designed by a legendary artisan, a ritual that twists reality. Even then, keep it to DV 5–6 and telegraph clearly: “This is a mythic challenge. Even with your power, it may fail.”

8.4 Failure Must Matter

At high tiers, a failed roll should never mean “nothing happens.” Instead:

- **A rival gains leverage.** “You cannot open the vault, but you see the Duke’s sigil on the lock – he knows someone inside.”
- **A secret becomes public.** “Your investigation fails, but the guard captain mentions your name to a reporter.”
- **A faction clock advances.** “The ritual continues. *Summoning* [8] ticks +1.”
- **An asset is compromised.** “Your safehouse is discovered – it is now *Neglected*.”

If failure merely delays action without changing the situation, you are not using the system to its full potential.

8.5 Using Bonds as the Primary Boon Engine

At high tiers, Boons should mainly come from **Bond-driven actions** (see 3.3.1). Encourage players to:

- Call on Bonds in difficult moments: “I owe you – I ask for your help now.”
- Expose allies or followers to danger to gain Boons.
- Accept new obligations or narrative fallout in exchange for Boons.

Example

The party’s captain needs to rally a wavering council. She has no Boons left. She turns to a Bonded ally: “I saved your sister’s life – now stand with me.” She marks the Bond, gains 1 Boon, and spends it to improve her Position to Dominant (see ??). The council listens.

8.6 Designing High-Tier Scenes

When planning an epic scene, ask:

1. **What changes if the characters succeed?**
2. **What compromises emerge on a Partial success?**
3. **What new dangers arise on a Miss?**

If the answer to “Miss” is “they try again,” increase the stakes, not the DV.

Example Scene: The Royal Vote

The party tries to convince the council to declare war on a neighboring realm.

- **Clean Success:** The vote passes; the army marches under their banner.
- **Success with Cost:** The vote passes, but a rival is appointed general.
- **Partial:** The vote is delayed; new clock *Council Deadlock* [4] appears.
- **Miss:** The vote fails. The rival declares war anyway – without the party’s leadership.

No DV was inflated. The stakes did the work.

8.7 Pacing and Scope

Embrace Longer Timelines

Time becomes a tool. Use downtime to:

- Advance faction clocks.
- Allow rumors to spread.
- Let players build legacies (fortresses, guilds, schools).

Abstract the Mundane

At high tiers, do not roll for climbing walls or picking common locks. Assume competence. Save rolls for choices that matter.

Let Players Command Armies

Treat armies as high-Cap followers (see 2.9.3). Use **Battle Clocks** (4–6 segments) for skirmishes. Do not resolve each soldier’s attack – abstract with leadership rolls.

8.8 Caveats and Warnings

- **Do not design adventures like Tier I.** Linear dungeons and small-scale fetch quests feel beneath legendary heroes. Instead, give them systemic problems: a curse that erases memory, a political schism, a dying god.
- **Do not hoard Boons.** Spend SB and optional Threat Pool points (see ??) to create memorable moments. Players earned their power – challenge them with creative complications, not starvation.
- **Do not fall into “superhero” mode.** The world should still react believably. A legendary warrior can be assassinated in their sleep. A master mage can be outmaneuvered politically.

8.9 Optional Epic Tools (Brief)

The following are covered in other chapters or appendixes:

- **Boss Generator** – See Appendix F (in the full GM’s Guide) for a card-based tool to create mythic adversaries.
- **Legacy Projects** – See Chapter 4 (3) for long-term clocks that span sessions.
- **Mythic Martial Tags** – Player-facing epic talents for warriors; see Chapter 6 of the *Player’s Guide*.
- **Mass Combat** – See optional rules in Appendix G for battle clocks and army followers.

The Mythic Failure Table

When a high-tier character fails a pivotal roll, describe a consequence from this table (or invent your own).

1X

d6 Consequence

- 1 An innocent dies because of your failure.
- 2 A rival claims the victory instead of you.
- 3 An artifact shatters, releasing a curse or a new threat.
- 4 Your reputation is damaged – lose 1 Mandate (if using, see 3.7.1).
- 5 An ally is captured or turned against you.
- 6 The problem spreads – a new clock appears (*Crisis* [4]).

8.10 Sample High-Tier Scenario: The Dying Sun

Premise: The realm's patron sun-spirit is fading. Without it, crops fail, undead rise, and the land dies.

Scope: Continental.

Clocks:

- *Sun's Fading* [10] – ticks each session, faster if neglected.
- *Cult of Eternal Night* [6] – a faction that worships the darkness.
- *Alliance of the Dawn* [8] – political support for a ritual to save the sun.

Success: The party finds a lost relic, performs a ritual, and restores the sun – but must choose a cost (e.g., their own lifespans, a Patron's demand).

Partial: The sun is saved, but the cult is not destroyed – they will return.

Miss: The sun dies. The party must lead a desperate exodus or accept a dark bargain for a new light.

This scenario cannot be solved by a single roll. It requires investigation, diplomacy, combat, and sacrifice – perfect for epic tier play.

8.11 Final Thought

At Tier IV and V, your players are no longer adventurers – they are **legends in the making**. Honor their power by giving them problems that require wisdom, sacrifice, and creativity to solve.

The dice still matter. Consequences still flow. But now, every choice echoes across nations and generations.

Make it legendary.

Chapter 9

The Known World: A Lore Compendium

This chapter presents a practical overview of the major regions of Fate’s Edge. For each area, you will find its dominant **fantasy subgenre**, the **primary conflicts** that drive adventure, and the **key stakeholders** (factions, leaders, and powers) that shape events. Use this as a quick reference when planning sessions or improvising.

9.1 A Note on Subgenres and Travel

Each region is designed as a distinct fantasy subgenre (see §??). When the party travels from one region to another, the genre shifts – a journey from the folk horror of the Mistlands to the political intrigue of Ecktoria should feel like turning the page to a different kind of story. Use the travel rules to blend these genres organically.

9.2 Acasia — “The Broken Province”

Genre: Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.

9.2.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Feuding petty kingdoms and warlords.
- Mercenary companies (the Black Banners) that shift loyalties with coin.
- The lingering “Curse” – a supernatural blight that twists roads and ruins.

9.2.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Margravine of the Broken March** – The highest authority, half-saint, half-tax-roll.
- **The Lame King** – A traveling pretender who makes law by pointing.
- **Blackwood Matriarchs** – Hedge-witches and feud-keepers.
- **Free Company Captains** – Pike and shot mercenaries between contracts.

9.2.0.0.3 Quote.

“In Acasia, every bargain is an echo of a promise once broken, and every drink tastes faintly of debt.”

9.2.0.0.4 Lore Note. *The road-judges of Acasia whisper that the Curse is not a blight but a slow accounting – every unpaid tithe, every broken oath, etched into the stone. “Pay what you owe,” they say, “or the road will eat the interest.”*

9.3 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Genre: Folk horror / pastoral quiet with dark undercurrents.

9.3.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- The “Neighbors” – fae or otherworldly powers that demand observance.
- Feuds between clan matriarchs that can last generations.
- Harvest tithes and famine pressure.

9.3.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Apple-Matron** – Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours.
- **The Pale Shepherd** – Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing.
- **Mummers’ Captain** – Keeps a chest of masks and stricter rules than church.
- **Lantern-Warden** – Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong.

9.3.0.0.3 Quote.

“Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth.”

9.3.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer’s note: “The Alearem pour the ninth cup only for the Hollow. They count to eight, then stop. I have seen a child count nine. The cup did not overflow – but the child’s reflection was no longer her own.”*

9.4 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Genre: Industrial / political / survival horror (underground).

9.4.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Resource scarcity (air, water, light, food) in sealed holds.
- Jurisdictional feuds – bell-code conflicts between crown and basilica.
- The “White Flood” – mountain thaw that becomes a river through routes.

9.4.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Vault-Queen** – Sovereign above and below.
- **High King Beneath the Peaks** – First among crowns by ancient concord.
- **True Masons** – Wanderers repairing ancient stonework.
- **Edgewalkers** – Prospectors and border scanners.

9.4.0.0.3 Quote.

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen.”

9.4.0.0.4 Lore Note. *Saikou Ira’s case files: “An Aeler tunnel-wright once told me, ‘The mountain does not forget a misplaced keystone. It waits – sometimes a year, sometimes a century – then settles the debt with a collapse.’ I have never seen a dwarf leave a stone unturned.”*

9.5 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Genre: Fae / mathematical / courtesy horror.

9.5.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Geasa and spoken taboos that bind without warning.
- Thorn Court vs. human law – jurisdiction debates.
- The Green Gate – a threshold that demands exact change in truths.

9.5.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Stone Prince of Aelinnel** – Mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed.
- **Lady of Thorns** – Hawthorn court sovereign; smiles like a snare.
- **Green Knight** – Duelist of paths and proofs.
- **Oath-Carver** – Sets promises in quartz so they can be seen.

9.5.0.0.3 Quote.

“The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper.”

9.5.0.0.4 Lore Note. *From the Grey Wanderer: “An Aelinnel bell-tender once told me, ‘We do not say ‘no’ to a spirit. We say, ‘That road is closed for repairs.’ The spirit nods and leaves. It is not a lie – the road is closed. To spirits.”*

9.6 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Genre: Military / mercenary / low fantasy warfare.

9.6.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Payday delays and supply shortages.
- Condotta units flipping sides mid-battle.
- Winter campaigns and frozen battlefields.

9.6.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Banner-Captain** – Griffon standard and a ledger of noble grudges.
- **The Black Colonel** – Legendary commander not seen in months, yet his banner still rides.
- **Clan-Mother (Ykrul)** – Wears war-braids from oath-breakers’ hair.
- **Veteran Sergeant** – Counts scars like coins.

9.6.0.0.3 Quote.

“A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it.”

9.6.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A camp whisper: “The Black Colonel died three winters ago. The banner rides because the company owes him a war. They will not stop until the debt is paid – in blood or gold.”*

9.7 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Genre: Political intrigue / legal drama / fallen empire.

9.7.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Rival dukes, abbesses, and parlements claiming legitimacy.
- Bread riots, grain shortages, and currency devaluation.
- The Everflame orthodoxy vs. reformist sects.

9.7.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Grand Magistrate** – Guardian of forms, breaker of them when needed.
- **High Priest of the Everflame** – Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt.
- **Duchess-Regent** – Speaks through cousins, rules through silence.
- **Censor’s Clerk** – “Misfiles” careers; knows which names to forget.

9.7.0.0.3 Quote.

“The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame.”

9.7.0.0.4 Lore Note. *Saikou Ira notes: “The Everflame’s inquisitors burn heretics on the Triumph Stairs. But the ashes are swept into the same crypts as the senators’ bones. In Ecktoria, even the dead cannot escape politics.”*

9.8 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

Genre: Viking / maritime / oath-bound raiding.

9.8.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds that turn weddings into funerals.
- Mistslands fog and misdirection – channels “move” without warning.
- Thing injunctions that forbid sailing until a grievance is heard.

9.8.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Sea-Queen** – Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law.
- **High Jarl** – First among raids, last to boast.
- **Volva of the Mist** – Oath-reader whose nod stills surf.
- **Skald** – Verses buy silence, start fights, end them.

9.8.0.0.3 Quote.

“The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds.”

9.8.0.0.4 Lore Note. *“A Linn skald’s verse: ‘The Thing-bell rings for the living. The drowned wait for a different bell – one that only sounds when the tide forgets its name.’”*

9.9 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Genre: Folk horror / gothic / supernatural dread.

9.9.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- The Direwood’s encroachment – undead and wraiths testing the bell-lines.
- Ward-salt shortages and bell-line failures.
- Aeler protectorate authority vs. local independence.

9.9.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Legate of the Mists** – Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree.
- **Bell-Warden** – Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay.
- **Salt-Monk** – Blesses pans and keeps ward-measure honest.
- **Mist-Seer** – Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks.

9.9.0.0.3 Quote.

“The bells here do more than mark time – they weave the very fabric of reality.”

9.9.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer’s warning: “In the Mistlands, never breathe deeply after the ninth bell. The fog remembers your breath, and one day it will ask for it back.”*

9.10 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Dyewater”

Genre: Urban / mercantile / noir.

9.10.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Guild rivalries and Exchange cornering.
- The “Curse” – dyewater omens and awakened curses in the canals.
- Condottieri flipping colors mid-contract.

9.10.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **The Matron** – Rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron.
- **Guildmistress of Dyers** – Stained hands, permits tighter than purse strings.
- **Bridge Bailiff** – Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath.
- **Night-Boat Smuggler (“Ravel”)** – Silent oar, louder favors.

9.10.0.0.3 Quote.

“In this city, every bridge is a ledger and every current carries coin.”

9.10.0.0.4 Lore Note. *Madam Serafine’s whisper: “The dye-water never truly washes out. A forger’s hands stay stained – not with colour, but with the memory of every seal they broke. You can see it in the way their fingers curl.”*

9.11 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Genre: Celtic / folk horror / taboo-driven.

9.11.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- The “No Ninth” taboo – omissions, unspoken names, missing steps.
- Bride-peace feasts that can end or restart feuds.
- The Green Host – spectral riders that appear when customs are broken.

9.11.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Matron of Wells** – Queen-mother in truth if not name.
- **Three-Isles King** – Elected by moots; whale-bone throne.
- **Lady Beneath** – Unseen queen who bargains in dreams.
- **Taboo-Witness** – Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals.

9.11.0.0.3 Quote.

“The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations.”

9.11.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer’s note: “I attended a moot on Theona. They counted every vote, every step, every cup – but never the ninth. When I asked why, the eldest said, ‘The ninth is not for us. It is for the ones who will come after. Let them count it.’”*

9.12 Thepyrgos — “City of a Thousand Stairs”

Genre: Byzantine / academic / arcane mystery.

9.12.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Synod edicts that proscribe or permit chants and rites.
- Iconoclast riots between competing faiths.
- Witch-hunters and arcane talent conscription.

9.12.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **The Archon** – Elected, entrenched, counting bells.
- **Lighthouse-Patriarch** – Reclusive seer who steers beacons in storms.
- **Nomophylax** – Law-scholar whose citations close mouths.
- **Palkar Captain** – Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy.

9.12.0.0.3 Quote.

“Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky.”

9.12.0.0.4 Lore Note. *Saikou Ira’s observation: “Thepyrgos’s witch-hunters carry censers of lead, not brass. ‘Brass is for faith,’ they say. ‘Lead is for certainty.’ I have never seen a lead censer cool.”*

9.13 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Genre: Highland clan / reiver / honour culture.

9.13.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds that last generations, settled by wergild in cattle or blood.
- Guest-right – breaking hospitality stains name worse than breaking a sword.
- Dwarf toll roads and clan independence.

9.13.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Lady of Tor** – Clan-chief in cloak and mail.
- **Council of Cairns** – Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry.
- **Feud-Broker** – Knows the weight of life in cattle and coin.
- **Wergild Counter** – Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others.

9.13.0.0.3 Quote.

“The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow.”

9.13.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Gray Wanderer’s memory: “An Ubral widow once told me, ‘My husband’s feud cost three cows and a boy’s finger. I paid the cows. The finger – that is still owed.’ She smiled. I did not ask more.”*

9.14 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Genre: Fairy tale / dark forest / fey remnant.

9.14.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Phasing ruins and star-roads that shift between worlds.
- Fae courts (Hazel vs. Alder) competing for influence.
- Imperial echoes – ancient shades still marching patrols.

9.14.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Hazel Queen** – Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law.
- **Alder King** – Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt.
- **The Huntsman** – Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him.
- **Pathweaver** – Knots safe routes into cord.

9.14.0.0.3 Quote.

“The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms.”

9.14.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Lethai-ar whisper: “The Valewood is not a place. It is a process. Every root, every leaf, every fallen emperor – all are being digested into something new. Walk softly, or you will join the meal.”*

9.15 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Genre: Courtly romance / chivalric / fractured kingdom.

9.15.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Rival dukes claiming the Sun-crown.
- Chevauchée – raiding parties that burn loyalty oaths as well as barns.
- Parlement divided – war by paperwork.

9.15.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Two Crowns** – Rival dukes, each crowned in rival cathedrals.
- **Queen-Mother** – Weaves alliances as if they were dowries.
- **Last Dauphin** – Rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers.
- **Marshal-Exile** – Sun-court’s hammer, now wielded by whoever pays.

9.15.0.0.3 Quote.

“The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains.”

9.15.0.0.4 Lore Note. *The Gray Wanderer: “In Vhasia, every castle flies two banners – one for the king who might return, and one for the lord who actually lives there. The third banner, the one for the truth, is never raised.”*

9.16 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Genre: Legal drama / low fantasy / frontier justice.

9.16.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Border disputes over hay-carts and toll rights.
- Legal duels – formal combat to settle property claims.
- The Queen’s progress – royal authority moving through semi-autonomous duchies.

9.16.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Warrior Queen** – Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind gaze.
- **Queen’s Justiciar** – Law on road, polite as a noose.
- **Fen Reeve** – Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds.
- **Master Advocate Halric** – Silver-tongued legal warrior.

9.16.0.0.3 Quote.

“Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle – the careful balance between order and freedom.”

9.16.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Justiciar’s saying: “The hedge does not move. The law moves. If you wake to find your boundary stone three feet east, do not curse the neighbour – curse the clerk who slept with the surveyor’s wife.”*

9.17 Ykrul (Orcs) — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Genre: Steppe nomad / saga / honour culture.

9.17.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Feuds and blood-price (wergild) in cattle or horses.
- Hostage strings – token kin left to secure treaties.
- White squalls and rasputitsa (spring melt) that seal passes.

9.17.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Khatun of Ring** – Camp-law and hostage strings.
- **Khagan’s Kin** – Sent to bind foedus with a look.
- **Sky-Speaker** – Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them price.
- **Kon’reh Masters** – Geometry arbiters and teachers.

9.17.0.0.3 Quote.

“The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honor of clans that have outlasted empires.”

9.17.0.0.4 Lore Note. *A Ykrul bone-singer’s whisper: “The wind carries more than snow. It carries the names of the forgotten. When a horse shies at nothing, it is because a name touched its ear. Speak the name, and the horse will calm – or run.”*

9.18 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

Genre: Pirate / noir / crime syndicate.

9.18.0.0.1 Primary Conflicts.

- Syndicate wars and the Salt Prince’s levy.
- Tide-driven smuggling routes that shift with the water.
- Cursed cargoes and fae bargains at the Crimson Docks.

9.18.0.0.2 Key Stakeholders.

- **Salt Prince** – Nominal ruler; real power in shadows.
- **Pirate Queen** – Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass.
- **Kraken’s Tongue** – Oracle who speaks in riddles and tides.

- **Syndicate Silent** – No names, just favors and faces.

9.18.0.0.3 Quote.

“The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths.”

9.18.0.0.4 Lore Note. *Madam Serafine’s advice: “In Zakov, a coin that stays warm is a curse. Spend it fast, or throw it into the sea. The Salt Prince’s collectors can smell interest from three docks away.”*

9.19 Other Regions (Brief)

For completeness, these areas appear in the comprehensive guide but are less central to the core setting:

- **Dungeon** – “**Living Infrastructure**” – A mythic underworld that breathes; genre: dungeon crawl as survival horror.
- **The Ways Between** – “**Spiritways & Veilways**” – Liminal paths between death and dreams; genre: metaphysical / dream-logic.
- **The Wilds** – “**Roads, Ruins, and Weather**” – A reskin palette for any terrain – forest, desert, tundra, coast.
- **Vilikari** – “**Laurels & Longhouses**” – A federated frontier mixing Utaran law with barbarian custom.

9.20 Using This Compendium at the Table

When preparing a session or improvising, consult the region’s entry for:

- **Genre** – to set the right mood.
- **Primary conflicts** – to generate immediate stakes.
- **Key stakeholders** – to populate scenes with recognizable NPCs.
- **Quote** – to read aloud as a flavour text.

Remember that travel rules (see §??) allow you to blend these genres as the party moves from one region to another.

Chapter 10

Example Play and GM Survival Guide

This chapter provides two practical resources:

1. A complete, annotated example session of **Fate's Edge** (Tier I–II).
2. A short **GM Survival Guide** – quick, actionable advice for common table situations.

All other GM guidance (session zero, safety tools, scene framing, clocks, etc.) is covered in other chapters. This chapter focuses on **seeing the system in action** and **handling the unexpected** – while keeping you, the GM, as a fellow player at the table.

10.1 The GM as Player: A Quick Refresher

Before diving into the example, remember: you are not a referee or a narrator robot. You are a **co-creator of drama**, entitled to surprise, delight, and even a little mischief. Your tools (SB, clocks, Threat Pool) are not punishments – they are your way of playing the game. When you spend a Story Beat to tick a clock, you are making a move. When you describe a guard's suspicious glance, you are adding tension. Enjoy it.

10.2 Example Session: The Heist at Lord Silas's Manor

This walkthrough follows three characters as they attempt to steal a sealed charter from a rival merchant prince. It demonstrates how scenes are framed, how pressure escalates, and how success, failure, Boons, and Story Beats work together – all while the GM plays an active, engaged role.

The Table

- **Valerius** — Ecktorian ex-legionary (Body 3, Warfare 2)
- **Elara** — Vhasian agent and negotiator (Wits 3, Sway 2)
- **Kael** — Dwarven geomancer (Lore 3, Geomancy 2)
- **GM** – Prepared to be surprised, to spend SB creatively, and to enjoy the ride.

The GM has prepared no fixed plot — only factions, motives, and clocks.

Campaign Context

The group seeks a sealed charter proving their patron's claim to a trade route. The charter is held by **Lord Silas**, a rival merchant prince.

- Silas is politically insulated.
- His manor is guarded but discreet.
- Exposure is as dangerous as failure.

Scene 1: Information Gathering

GM frames: “You are in Silkstrand’s lower markets at dusk. Silas’s manor rises above you. Guards are visible, but relaxed.” (The GM enjoys setting the atmospheric hook.)

Stakes: Success = identify an entry vector; Failure = guard suspicion escalates. **Clock introduced:** *Manor Alert* [4]

10.2.0.0.1 Action. Elara scouts using **Wits + Subterfuge**. Position: Controlled. She rolls 2 Successes vs DV 3 → **Partial Success**.

10.2.0.0.2 Resolution. GM rules:

- Elara identifies a servant gate (progress achieved).
- GM advances *Manor Alert* by 1 (cost).
- Elara gains **1 Boon**.

The fiction advances; pressure is visible. The GM is happy – a Partial is the most interesting outcome.

Scene 2: Entry

The group scales the outer wall at night. Position: Desperate. **Stakes:** Success = inside undetected; Failure = immediate pursuit.

10.2.0.0.3 Action. Valerius rolls **Body + Athletics**. He rolls 4 Successes including a 10 → **Clean Success with flourish**.

10.2.0.0.4 Resolution.

- The group enters cleanly.
- GM reduces future Position penalties inside.
- No Story Beat is spent.

Strong rolls relieve pressure without removing future danger. The GM celebrates the player’s cool moment.

Scene 3: Complication Inside

Kael attunes to the stone to locate the vault. Position: Controlled. Kael rolls 0 Successes → **Miss**.

10.2.0.0.5 Resolution.

- Kael gains **2 Boons**.
- GM spends 1 SB to introduce a servant unexpectedly entering.
- GM advances *Manor Alert* by 1.

The failure creates momentum rather than stalling play. The GM smiles – now they get to describe the servant’s wide eyes.

Scene 4: Social Pivot

Elara calms the servant. Position: Risky. New clock: *Servant Panic* [4]. She rolls a **Success with Cost**.

10.2.0.0.6 Resolution.

- The servant is convinced.
- GM spends SB to advance *Servant Panic* by 2.
- The group now operates under time pressure.

The GM is now thinking: “Will they make it before the servant screams?”

Scene Cut

The GM cuts immediately: “You have the vault location. You also hear boots on marble.” This prevents overplaying and preserves tension. The GM enjoys the players’ anxious glances.

Scene 5: The Vault

The vault is magically reinforced. Clock: *Vault Integrity* [6]. Kael attempts a geomantic bypass. He rolls Partial (2 Successes vs DV 4).

10.2.0.0.7 Resolution. GM chooses proportional progress:

- *Vault Integrity* advances by 2.
- GM takes a Story Beat instead of increasing Alert.
- Kael gains 1 Boon.

Partials are *GM-shaped outcomes*. The GM feels creative.

Scene 6: Extraction

The vault opens as guards arrive. *Manor Alert* at 3/4. Valerius creates a distraction while Elara escapes with the charter. The final roll succeeds — but the GM fills *Manor Alert* as the cost.

10.2.0.0.8 Outcome.

- Charter secured.
- Silas knows he was robbed.
- New faction clock begins: *Silas's Retaliation* [6].

The GM is already planning the next session’s opening scene.

Session Close**End-of-session review:**

- Boons generated primarily from Partials and Misses.
- Story Beats spent to escalate, not negate success.
- New clocks seeded future conflict.

The session ends with a clear win, lasting consequences, and visible momentum. The GM is satisfied — they were surprised, they played, and the table had fun.

10.3 High-Tier Play in Brief (Tier IV–V)

At Tier IV–V, the core mechanics remain the same, but the context shifts. Here are the key differences, illustrated by a brief scenario.

What Changes

- **Larger dice pools** → more automatic successes, fewer Misses.
- **Fewer Boons earned** → Boons become precious, strategic currency.
- **Failure has wider consequences** – a missed roll can shift faction clocks or expose an asset.
- **Bonds and Assets** become the primary sources of Boons.

Example: House Morrenn Conflict

A Tier IV party leads a regional faction against House Morrenn. Campaign clocks: *Morrenn Ascendancy* [6] and *Faction Stability* [6].

10.3.0.0.1 Scene: Council Confrontation. Elara spends her only Boon on a Tier IV talent, succeeds, but the GM spends a Story Beat to mark her as a personal enemy – creating a new clock *Targeted Retaliation* [4].

10.3.0.0.2 Scene: Asset Pressure. Assassins strike the safehouse. No Boons remain, so Valerius accepts Harm and a worse Position to protect NPCs. *Faction Stability* advances by 1 – people saw leadership under fire.

10.3.0.0.3 Scene: Risky Ritual. Kael attempts a geomantic collapse to delay troops. He rolls a Miss, gains 2 Boons, but *Morrenn Ascendancy* advances and long-term fallout (destabilised ley fault) appears.

10.3.0.0.4 Result. The party ends with 1–2 Boons, strained assets, and multiple clocks near resolution. No DV inflation was needed – the stakes and resource scarcity did the work.

Key Takeaway

At high tier, power comes from reach, not safety. Boons are for decisive moments, not routine re-rolls. Failure is often chosen to regain leverage.

10.4 GM Survival Guide

This section offers quick, actionable advice for the most common GM challenges. It assumes you have read the core rules and other chapters – this is the “cheat sheet” for the table.

When Players Go Off the Rails

- Do not panic. Ask: “What is your goal?” (not “How do you do that?”).
- Name the simplest obstacle in their way – then set Position and DV.
- If they ignore the obvious, let the world react. A missed roll means the guard they bypassed earlier shows up.
- **GM as player:** Enjoy their creativity. Your job is to say “yes, but” and “no, but” – not to block them.

When a Scene Stalls

- Ask a leading question: “Who are you trying to impress?” or “What are you afraid of here?”

- Tick a clock. “While you argue, the fire spreads – *Collapse* [4] advances 1.”
- Cut to another player. Shift spotlight.
- **GM as player:** A stalled scene is your signal to introduce a new element. Have fun with it.

When You Don’t Know a Rule

- Make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Say: “We’ll do it this way for now; look it up later.”
- Default to DV 3, Controlled Position, and a consequence that feels right.
- Trust your gut. The system is robust.
- **GM as player:** Uncertainty is part of the game. Embrace it – the dice will surprise you.

How to Say “No” (Without Firing the Player)

- “No, but...” – offer a harder path, a cost, or a requirement.
- “Yes, but...” – let them succeed, then add a complication.
- “Let’s find out” – call for a roll with high DV and Desperate Position. The dice decide.
- **GM as player:** Saying “no” is boring. Saying “no, but” is a gift to the story.

Using Clocks Effectively

- Name clocks clearly: *Alarm Raised* [4], not “Bad Stuff [6]”.
- Only keep 1–3 clocks active per scene. More than that is noise.
- Tick a clock on a Miss or a Partial – even if the player otherwise succeeds.
- **GM as player:** Clocks are your visible toys. Tick them with relish.

Managing Player Spotlight

- Rotate by environment: scholar in the library, fighter on the wall.
- Use Bonds to pass focus: “You owe Rina – what do you do to protect her?”
- Quick check-in: “While that happens, what is your character doing?”
- **GM as player:** Giving everyone a moment means you get to see different parts of the story.

When You Feel Burnt Out

- Call a break. Even five minutes resets the table.
- Ask players to recap – they will remind you of forgotten details.
- End the session early if needed. No game is better than a bad game.
- Use a published adventure or a random generator for one week. Give yourself a rest.
- **GM as player:** Your fun matters. If you are not enjoying it, talk to your group.

Final Survival Mantra

Set the DV low. Make the world react honestly. Let the pressure do the work. And remember – you are playing too.

— The Fate’s Edge GM Mantra

If the table feels engaged, tense, and safe – you are running the game correctly. If you are also having fun, you are running it brilliantly.

Chapter 11

Appendices

This chapter collects quick-reference tables, optional rules, and GM tools into four thematic appendices. Use them as needed at the table. For additional player-facing reference, see the *Player's Guide* appendices.

Appendix A: Core Reference Tables

Outcome Matrix

Case	Name	Guidance
$S \geq DV, C = 0$	Clean Success	Deliver the intent crisply.
$S \geq DV, C > 0$	Success & Cost	Grant intent; spend or bank SB for complications.
$0 < S < DV$	Partial	Progress; award 1 Boon.
$S = 0$	Miss	No progress; award 2 Boons; spend or bank SB.

Story Beat (SB) Spend Menu

- **1 SB:** Minor pressure – noise, trace, +1 segment on a relevant clock.
- **2 SB:** Moderate setback – alarm raised, lose cover or advantage, lesser foe appears.
- **3 SB:** Serious trouble – reinforcements arrive, key gear breaks temporarily, tick a campaign front.
- **4+ SB:** Major turn – trap springs, authority arrives, scene shifts dramatically.

Position Descriptions

- **Dominant:** Act on your terms. Consequences are manageable.
- **Controlled:** Normal risk and reward. Failure has a real cost.
- **Desperate:** Odds stacked against you. Failure could be catastrophic.

Difficulty Ladder

DV	Name	When to Use
2	Routine	Clear intent, modest stakes, controlled environment.
3	Pressured	Time pressure, mild opposition, partial information.
4	Hard	Hostile conditions, active opposition, precise timing.
5+	Extreme	Multiple constraints, high stakes, dramatic failure.

Boon Economy Quick Guide

- **Holding cap:** 5 Boons maximum.
- **Carryover:** At the end of each scene, reduce held Boons to a maximum of 2.
- **Conversion:** 2 Boons $\rightarrow$ 1 XP, once per session during downtime (max 2 XP per session via conversion).
- **Spending:** Re-roll a die, activate an asset, improve Position, or power certain Rites.

Mechanical Constraints

- **Assist Max:** +3 dice total per roll (Exceptional Coordination allows +4 from one follower).
- **Boon Max:** 5 total; 2 $\rightarrow$ 1 XP conversion once per session (max 2 XP via conversion).
- **Follower Independent Action:** Once per scene (party-wide).
- **Over-Stack:** Two or more structural advantages on the same action $\rightarrow$ start one obstacle at +1 DV or GM banks +1 SB.

Harm Levels and Effects

Harm Level	SB Generation	Penalty	Recovery
Minor	1 SB (next 2 rolls)	−1 die (related actions)	Rest or basic care
Moderate	1 SB (next roll)	−1 die (most actions)	Medical treatment
Severe	2 SB (next roll)	−2 dice (most actions)	Extended care
Critical	3 SB (next roll)	Incapacitated	Major intervention

Range Bands

Close Arm's length, grappling distance.

Near Same room or immediate area.

Far Visible but not immediately reachable.

Absent Off-screen; requires a scene change.

Movement Actions

- **Move:** Shift one range band (CloseNear or NearFar).
- **Dash:** Shift two bands as your full action.
- **Disengage:** Test to leave an enemy's Close range without provoking an opportunity attack.
- **Charge / Skirmish:** Full-turn actions that move two bands and attack, costing 1 Fatigue.

See 2.7.1 for complete action economy.

Supply Clock States

Full (0 segments) Well-provisioned, no penalty.

Low (2 segments) Minor friction – resource checks at −1 die.

Dangerously Low (3 segments) Each PC gains Fatigue 1.

Empty (4 segments) Severe penalties – starvation or thirst risk.

Travel Clock Sizes

4 segments Short, straightforward leg.

6 segments Standard leg.

8 segments Extended or complex journey.

10 segments Epic or highly dangerous passage.

XP Costs

Improvement	Cost	Downtime
Attribute increase	new rating × 3 XP	new rating days
Skill increase	new level × 2 XP	new level days
On-Screen Follower	Cap ² XP	1–3 days
Minor Asset	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset	12 XP	1 month

Upkeep (Condensed)

Frequency: Once per downtime period.

- **Efficient (higher XP, less time):** Upkeep XP = $\max(1, \frac{AcquisitionXP}{3})$.

- **Intensive (1 XP, dedicated action):** One full downtime action.
- **Failure to pay:** Follower becomes Wary (or Seized if already Wary); Asset becomes Neglected (or Compromised if already Neglected).

Appendix B: Optional Rules and Tactical Tools

Grid-Based Combat

Use a square or hex grid with Zones of Control (ZoC).

11.0.0.0.1 ZoC rules:

- Entering an enemy's Zone of Control ends your movement – you are engaged.
- You cannot move through an enemy's ZoC.
- Leaving a ZoC requires the Disengage action (DV 4–6) or spending 1 Boon.
- Flank: +1 die to attack. Rear: +1 die and +1 Effect.

11.0.0.0.2 Push-Through: Roll *Body + Athletics* vs. $DV = 2 + enemyTier$. Choose a cost on success: Position worsens by one step, –1 die on the action, or the enemy gets a free opportunity attack.

Detailed Warfare (Mass Combat)

Treat an army as a high-Cap Follower (see 2.9.3) with its own clocks:

- **Supply Clock** (6–8 segments): When empty, the army suffers severe penalties.
- **Morale Clock** (6–8 segments): When full, the army routs.
- **Command rolls** (Presence + Command or Wits + Tactics) advance objective clocks (e.g., *Break Their Line* [6]).
- **Battle's Edge:** Story Beats generated by command rolls can be spent on fog-of-war complications – false orders, broken supply wagons, or a messenger's death.

Hex-Based Exploration

Map a region in 6-mile hexes. Entering a hex requires a *Wits + Survival* roll (DV set by terrain). Outcomes determine discovery (find a point of interest), danger (ambush, hazard), or becoming lost (add a clock segment to find the way out).

Miniatures and Tactical Layer

Miniatures Mode — Speed Defaults

Base DV: $DV = Tier + 2 + Keywords$ (elevation +1, [WARD] +1, Disengage base DV 4).

Critical Hit (10): Bump Position one step; if already Dominant, Push or Pull the target 1 hex *or* gain +1 automatic success.

Zone of Control (ZoC): Entering or leaving a hex adjacent to an enemy provokes one Reaction (Free Strike or Shove 1 hex).

Heat: On a critical hit, the GM may spend 1 Heat (a resource tracked per scene) to degrade Position or trigger a terrain hazard.

Hex Keywords

Difficult: Costs 2 movement points per hex. **Elevation:** Attacks from lower ground suffer +1 DV. **ZoC:** Provokes a Reaction on crossing.

Altar [WARD]: -1 die to attacks (or attacker may spend 2 Fatigue to ignore).

Incorporeal: Ignores Difficult terrain; can pass through occupied hexes but cannot end movement in one.

Sample NPCs

11.0.0.0.3 Encounters (Tier I–II)

- **Bandit Skirmisher:** Body 2, Wits 2. Melee 2, Stealth 1.
- **Ykrul Rider:** Body 4, Wits 3. Riding 3, Melee 3.
- **Street Bravo:** Presence 3, Body 2. Dueling 3.

11.0.0.0.4 Foils & Rivals (Tier II–III)

- **Ambitious Scribe:** Wits 3, Presence 3. Intrigue 3, Lore 2.
- **Mercenary Captain:** Body 4, Spirit 3. Command 3, Melee 4.
- **Flame Preacher:** Presence 4, Spirit 3. Oratory 4, Faith 3.

11.0.0.0.5 Prestige NPCs (Tier IV–V)

- **High Elf Loremaster:** Wits 5, Spirit 4. Lore 5, Arcana 4.
- **Dwarven Forge-Patriarch:** Body 5, Spirit 4. Craft 5, Command 4.
- **Ykrul Warglord:** Body 5, Presence 4. Command 4, Melee 5.

Common Rolls (GM Screen Reference)

Athletics: climb (*Body*+Athletics), time a leap (*Wits*+Athletics)

Stealth: shadow patrol (*Wits*+Stealth), hold still (*Spirit*+Stealth)

Endurance: resist cold (*Spirit*+Endurance), push through pain (*Spirit*+Endurance)

Craft: blueprint (*Wits*+Craft), brace a door (*Body*+Craft)

Melee: break guard (*Body*+Melee), bind a blade (*Wits*+Melee)

Ranged: leading shot (*Wits*+Ranged), loose in a squall (*Spirit*+Ranged)

Brawl: grapple (*Body*+Brawl), feint (*Wits*+Brawl)

Tactics: ambush lane (*Wits*+Tactics), coordinate a retreat (*Presence*+Tactics)

Diplomacy: audience (*Presence*+Diplomacy), draft terms (*Wits*+Diplomacy)

Sway: haggle (*Presence*+Sway), sell a risky plan (*Presence*+Sway)

Deception: lie under scrutiny (*Presence*+Deception), misdirect guard (*Wits*+Deception)

Performance: captivate a crowd (*Presence*+Performance), mimic voice (*Wits*+Performance)

Subterfuge: talk past a checkpoint (*Presence*+Subterfuge), case a routine (*Wits*+Subterfuge)

Streetwise: find a fence (*Presence*+Streetwise), sift rumors (*Wits*+Streetwise)

Arcana: read a ward anchor (*Wits*+Arcana), hold a rite steady (*Spirit*+Arcana)

Mechanics: diagnose a lock (*Wits*+Mechanics), field-rig a pump (*Body*+Mechanics)

Investigation: reconstruct a scene (*Wits*+Investigation), interview a witness (*Presence*+Investigation)

Lore: cite local custom (*Presence*+Lore), perform a rite (*Spirit*+Lore)

Nature: read weather (*Wits*+Nature), calm a

mount (*Presence*+Nature)

Command: rally allies (*Presence*+Command),

Medicine: stabilise a wound (*Wits*+Medicine), hold the line (*Spirit*+Command)

cut away rot (*Body*+Medicine)

Fast Boundaries:

- **Locks & Traps:** Mechanical = Mechanics + Attribute; Arcane = Arcana + Attribute.
- **People vs. Mechanisms:** Subterfuge for social infiltration; Stealth to avoid detection; Mechanics or Arcana to bypass a physical or magical barrier.
- **Formal vs. Informal:** Diplomacy for courts and treaties; Sway for bargaining and personal persuasion.

Appendix C: Deck and Magic Reference

Deck Types and Meanings

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card) Spade = Place, Heart = Actor, Club = Pressure, Diamond = Leverage.

Deck of Consequences (scene drama) Hearts = Social/Emotional, Spades = Harm/Escalation, Clubs = Material Cost, Diamonds = Magical/Spiritual.

Important: Never mix suit meanings across different deck types.

Deck Usage Procedure

After a roll that generates Story Beats:

1. **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or clock ticks (see 11).
2. **Optional Deck Draw:** Draw up to $\min(SB, 3)$ cards and synthesise a single narrative twist guided by the suits and the highest rank.

Rank Severity Guide

Ace–3 Minor inconvenience or flavour.

4–6 Moderate setback.

7–9 Significant consequence.

10–King Major fallout with lasting effects.

Deck of Consequences Interpretation

Hearts (Emotional/Social) Ace–3: awkward social moment; 4–6: relationship strain; 7–9: betrayal; 10–King: exile or shattered alliance.

Spades (Harm/Escalation) Ace–3: bruise or Fatigue; 4–6: wound or damaged gear; 7–9: severe injury; 10–King: death or permanent loss.

Clubs (Material/Cost) Ace–3: minor resource loss; 4–6: gear failure or debt; 7–9: major asset lost; 10–King: total ruin.

Diamonds (Magical/Spiritual) Ace–3: omen or whisper; 4–6: curse or spirit appears; 7–9: arcane backlash; 10–King: reality bends temporarily.

Magic Paths Comparison

Path	Requirements	Key Feature	Risk Type
Caster (Freeform)	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Improvisational spellcasting	Backlash (4.3)
Runekeeper (Rites)	Thiasos (2 XP) + Codex (4 XP)	Structured Patron Rites	Obligation (4.4)
Invoker (Symbols)	Patron's Symbol (4 XP each)	Ritual precision, emergency casting	Symbol compromise

DV Reference for Rites

$$DV = \max(\text{ObligationCost} \sim \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier})$$

Obligation	Spirit 0	Spirit 1	Spirit 2	Spirit 3–4	Tier 1	Tier 2	Tier 3
1	1	1	1	1	1	2	3
2	2	1	1	1	1	2	3
3	3	2	1	1	1	2	3
4	4	3	2	1	1	2	3
5	5	4	3	2	1	2	3
6	6	5	4	3	1	2	3
7	7	6	5	4	1	2	3

Casting Loop Summary

1. **Channel:** Wits + Arcana to gather magical potential.
2. **Weave:** Wits + Art (or appropriate magical skill) to shape the effect.
3. **Backlash:** The GM spends SB generated during the roll to impose thematic consequences (see 4.3).

Eight Elements of Magic

Earth Solidity, stability, foundation.

Fire Energy, transformation, destruction.

Air Movement, speed, freedom.

Water Fluidity, healing, adaptability.

Fate Destiny, inevitability, causality.

Life Vitality, creation, growth.

Luck Chance, unpredictability.

Death/Dreams Endings, thresholds, the subconscious.

Appendix D: Campaign Management

Campaign Clock Examples

- **Mandate Advancement:** Public victories, crisis resolution, recognition by powerful factions (see 3.7.1).
- **Crisis Advancement:** Rival faction gains influence, asset neglect, betrayal, scandal (see 3.7.2).

Follower and Asset Condition States

Maintained Full capability, no penalties.

Neglected –1 die penalty; narrative wear and tear.

Compromised Unavailable until repaired or recovered through downtime.

See 2.9.3 for detailed rules.

Faction Loyalty Scale (Optional)

Track faction standing on a simple –3 to +3 scale.

–3 **Enemy** Actively works against the party.

0 **Neutral** Indifferent.

+3 **Ally** Will sacrifice for the party.

Adjust by ± 1 after major interactions (saving or betraying the faction).

Campaign Pacing (Arc Structure)

1. **Introduction** (1–2 sessions): Establish stakes, hook the players.
2. **Development** (2–4 sessions): Complications multiply, alliances form.
3. **Climax** (1–2 sessions): Major confrontation, critical choices.
4. **Resolution** (1 session): Consequences land, new status quo established.

Appendix E: Safety and Inclusivity

X-Card System

- **X-Card:** “I’m not comfortable – change direction immediately.” No explanation required.
- **O-Card:** “I’m excited – lean into this element.”
- **N-Card:** “I need a break – pause the scene.”

Keep cards visible. Model appropriate use as the GM.

Script Change

Ask at appropriate moments:

- **Pause:** “Are you okay with this content?”
- **Rewind:** “Would you like to go back and change something?”
- **Fast Forward:** “Would you like to skip ahead?”

Inclusive Worldbuilding

- Research real cultures thoroughly when drawing inspiration.
- Avoid stereotypes; build characters with depth and agency.
- Provide character options that do not rely on real-world cultural markers.
- Use high-contrast, readable materials for accessibility.

Conflict Resolution

When conflicts arise at the table:

1. Pause gameplay.
2. Discuss privately if needed.
3. Focus on understanding, not assigning fault.
4. Find collaborative solutions.
5. Document any agreements.

Common solutions: the GM’s ruling stands for the session; research the rule later; adjust future play.